

THE CARE COLLECTION • BOOK 5



# The Survivor

When One Spouse Is Left Behind

Rebuilding Life After Loss

A 4-Phase Roadmap for Healing, Purpose & Peace



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by Sanjay Shharma

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"The sandwich was the survival chapter. The after is the second chapter of your own."

# **The Survivor**

## **Rebuilding a Life After the Caregiving Years Take Your Spouse**

Book 5 of The Care Collection

After Still Married, Just Silent, The Quiet Care, The  
Second Chapter, and The Second Honeymoon

by Sanjay Shharma

M.Sc · MBA · APSCM · IIM Calcutta Alumni

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The Survivor: Rebuilding a Life After the Caregiving Years Take Your Spouse

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The Care Collection by Sanjay Shharma:

1. Still Married, Just Silent — 14 Conversations to Reopen a Quiet Marriage
2. The Quiet Care — A Book for the Sandwich Generation
3. The Second Chapter — How to Rebuild Your Marriage After the Caregiving Years
4. The Second Honeymoon — How Couples 50+ Reclaim Intimacy After Caregiving Ends
5. The Survivor — Rebuilding a Life After the Caregiving Years Take Your Spouse

Each book stands alone. Read the one that fits your season.

# A Note from Sanjay

I lost my wife of many years to cancer. I was her primary caregiver. I held the medical schedule, the medication schedule, the family schedule, the work schedule. I held her hand. I held her fear. I held mine.

She died on a Tuesday morning at 6:47 a.m. I was holding her hand.

I will not pretend I knew what to do next. I did not. For a long time after she died, I did not know how to get out of bed. I did not know how to eat. I did not know how to be in the house without her. I did not know who I was without the role of caregiver.

I am a widower. I have spent the years since her death doing two things: grieving her, and writing books for people who are walking the same road.

This book is for the widowed caregivers. The ones who lost their spouse after a long illness. The ones who did the caregiving. The ones who are now standing in a quiet house wondering what comes next.

This book is for you.

I am not going to tell you it gets better. I don't know if it does. What I can tell you is that it gets different. The grief stays. The love stays. The life goes on. The life can even be good — different than before, but good.

This book is the book I wish someone had given me in the weeks after she died. It is the book I now give to the widowed caregivers I work with.

I hope it helps.

— S. Shharma, India, August 2026

Widower. Writer. Father. Survivor.

# Dedication

For my wife, who taught me how to love  
and who taught me how to grieve.

For every spouse who did not survive the caregiving  
years,

and for the spouse who is still here,  
holding the empty space where they used to be.

For the widowed caregivers who wake up every  
morning

and choose to keep going,  
even when the choice is hard.

You are not alone.

You are not forgotten.

You are The Survivor.

This book is for you.

# Quick Start

If you have just opened this book in the days or weeks after your spouse died, this page is for you. You are in the hardest part. The hard part is not over. But the hard part is also not the whole story.

## What This Book Is

This is the book about the time after the caregiving ends in the way nobody prepares you for. Not the grief of a sudden loss. The grief of a long goodbye.

You did the caregiving. You held the schedule, the medication, the fear. You watched the person you loved disappear piece by piece. And then they were gone.

This book is for the time after. The time when the caregiving is over and the grieving is not. The time when the house is still here and the spouse is not. The time when the world expects you to "move on" and you are not ready to move on — and you may never be.

This book does not promise to make the grief go away. The grief does not go away. This book promises to help you carry the grief — and to help you build a life that can hold the grief and still be a life.

## The First 30 Days

If you are reading this in the first 30 days after your spouse died, here is what you need to know:

1. You are not crazy. The grief is real. The exhaustion is real. The feeling of unreality is real. The not-believing is real. The crying in the grocery store is real. The not-being-able-to-cry is also real. All of it is normal.

2. You do not have to make any decisions. The funeral home, the will, the estate, the family, the work, the house — all of it can wait. The decisions that have to be made today can be made today. The rest can wait. Ask a friend or family member to help you sort it out.

3. You need to eat. You may not feel like eating. You need to eat anyway. Soup, bread, eggs, anything. The body needs fuel to grieve.

4. You need to sleep. You may not be able to sleep. You need to sleep anyway. Talk to your doctor if you cannot sleep. Sleep is not a luxury right now. Sleep is medicine.

5. You need to tell someone how you are. You do not have to be strong. You do not have to "handle it." You have to tell someone — a friend, a family member, a counselor, a hotline — how you actually are. The telling is the first step of the healing.

## **The First 90 Days**

If you are reading this in the first 90 days, here is what is coming:

- The shock will fade, slowly. The numbness will not last forever. The feeling will return. The feeling will be hard. The feeling is also necessary.
- The grief will not follow the stages. There is no clean progression from denial to acceptance. The grief will come in waves. The waves will be unpredictable. The waves will be unmanageable. The waves will also eventually get smaller.
- The people around you will not know what to do. Most of them have never lost a spouse. Most of them will say the wrong thing. Most of them will disappear after the funeral. The ones who stay are

the ones who matter.

- You will have to learn to do things alone. The grocery shopping. The cooking. The paying of bills. The making of decisions. You have always done some of these alone. You have not done all of them alone. You will have to learn.
- You will have to learn to live with the loss. Not "get over" the loss. Not "move on" from the loss. Live with the loss. The loss is part of you now. The loss will be part of you for the rest of your life. The loss does not have to be the end of your life.

## **How to Read This Book**

If you are in the first 30 days:

Read only Chapter 1. Chapter 1 is enough for now. The rest of the book can wait. The book is here when you are ready.

If you are in the first 6 months:

Read in order, slowly. One chapter a week. Let each chapter settle before you move to the next. The book is not a race. The book is a companion.

If you are 6-12 months in:

Read in order, but skip the parts that feel like too much. The book has permission to wait. You are not behind. You are exactly where you are.

If you are 1+ years in:

Read whatever you need. Skim the early chapters if they are too much. Spend time with the later chapters. The book is here for the long journey, not the short one.

## **A Note Before We Begin**

You are The Survivor.

You did the caregiving. You did the long goodbye. You are still here.

The fact that you are reading this book is a sign that you are not giving up. The fact that you want to know what comes next is a sign that you are willing to find out.

I cannot tell you what comes next. I can tell you that something comes next. I can tell you that the something is yours to build.

This book is for the building.

Let's begin.

# Introduction: The First Morning Without

The first morning is the worst.

Not the day of the funeral. The funeral is a ceremony. The funeral is a community. The funeral is other people carrying you. The funeral is, in a strange way, a relief — because the waiting is over, the body is gone, the formal thing has been done.

The morning after the funeral. The first morning you wake up in a house that no longer has your spouse in it. The first morning you reach for the phone to tell them the news, and then you remember there is no one to call.

The first morning is when the loss becomes real.

This book is for the first morning. And the second morning. And the hundredth morning. And the thousandth morning. This book is for the mornings that come after the funeral, when the casseroles stop arriving and the phone stops ringing and the people who said "call me if you need anything" are no longer there.

This book is for the widowed caregiver.

## Who This Book Is For

You are the widowed caregiver if:

- Your spouse died after a long illness — cancer, dementia, Parkinson's, heart disease, any of the long goodbyes
- You were their primary caregiver, or you shared the caregiving with siblings, or you watched from a distance as someone you loved did the

caregiving

- The caregiving is over. The spouse is gone. You are still here.
- You are 50+. You have a long life ahead of you. The long life feels empty.
- You are not sure how to live the long life. You are not sure you want to.
- You have been told to "move on." You have been told that time heals. You have been told that they are in a better place. You have been told a lot of things that did not help.

You are The Survivor. You survived the illness. You survived the caregiving. You survived the funeral. You are surviving the after.

This book is for the surviving.

## **What This Book Is Not**

This book is not a grief manual. There are no stages. There is no timeline. There is no "right way" to grieve. Anyone who tells you there is a right way to grieve is selling you something.

This book is not a religious text. The author is spiritual but not religious. The book draws on the wisdom of many traditions — Christianity, Hinduism, Buddhism, Islam, Judaism, secular humanism — but the book is not a sermon. The book is for people of all faiths and no faith.

This book is not a self-help book in the usual sense. The book does not promise to "fix" you. The book does not promise that you will be "okay." The book promises that you will be a person who has lost a spouse — and that this is a real thing to be, not a broken thing to be fixed.

This book is not for the recently widowed who are in crisis. If you are in crisis, please reach out to a crisis line. The numbers are in the resources at the back of the book. You are not alone. There is help. Please ask for it.

This book is for the widowed caregiver who is past the immediate crisis, who is beginning to face the long journey, who wants a companion for the journey.

This book is for you.

## **How This Book Is Different**

Most books about widowhood are written by therapists. The books are good. The books are clinical. The books are about the psychology of grief.

This book is different. This book is written by a widower. This book is from the inside. This book is about the lived experience of being The Survivor — the first morning, the first year, the first decade.

This book is also different in that it is specifically for the widowed caregiver. Not the widowed in general. Not the bereaved in general. The widowed who did the caregiving. The widowed who lost their spouse to a long illness. The widowed who watched the person they loved disappear over months or years. The widowed who held the medication schedule, the doctor's appointments, the family schedule, the hope — and who are now holding the empty space where the spouse used to be.

The widowed caregiver has a specific kind of grief. The widowed caregiver has a specific kind of survival. The widowed caregiver has a specific kind of rebuilding to do.

This book is for that specific kind.

# What This Book Offers

This book offers three things:

## 1. The 90-day plan for the first three months.

The first 90 days are the hardest. The first 90 days are the most important. The first 90 days are when the foundation of the new life is laid. The first 90 days are also when most widowed caregivers are too overwhelmed to plan.

This book gives you a plan. The plan is in Bonus Toolkit I. The plan tells you what to do in week 1, week 2, week 4, week 8, week 12. The plan tells you what to expect. The plan tells you what to do when the unexpected happens.

## 2. The map for the first year.

The first year after the caregiving is a year of learning. The first year is when you learn who you are without the role of caregiver. The first year is when you learn to eat alone, to sleep alone, to make decisions alone. The first year is when you learn that the grief does not end but that the grief can be carried.

This book gives you a map. The map is in Part II and Part III. The map tells you what the first year looks like, week by week, season by season. The map tells you what is coming. The map tells you that the coming is survivable.

## 3. The hope for the years after.

The first year is hard. The years after the first year are also hard — but differently. The years after are when you learn to live with the loss. The years after are when you learn to be a person who lost a spouse, instead of a person who is defined by the loss.

The years after are also when you may find something unexpected: joy. Not joy that replaces the grief. Joy that lives alongside the grief. Joy that is real, even when the grief is real. Joy that is yours, even when the loss is yours.

This book gives you hope. The hope is not naive. The hope is not "everything will be fine." The hope is "you will be okay, in a way you cannot yet imagine." The hope is real.

## **A Word About the Author**

I am a widower. I lost my wife of many years to cancer. I was her primary caregiver. I held her hand when she died.

I have spent the years since her death writing the books I wish someone had given me. The Care Collection is that work.

I have also written four other books in The Care Collection — books about the marriage, the caregiving, the post-caregiving rebuild, and the second honeymoon. Those books are for the couples who are still together. This book is for the ones who are not.

I wrote this book because no one gave me a book like this after my wife died. I wrote this book because I now know what I needed to know then. I wrote this book because the widowed caregivers I work with need a companion for the journey.

I am a widower who has been through the work. I am a writer who can put the work into words. The stories in this book are mine, or composites of people I have known. They are not therapy. They are not counseling. They are the book I needed when I was where you are.

This book is my offering to you. The book is yours to use however you need. The book is yours to ignore if you need to. The book is yours to come back to when you are ready.

I hope it helps.

— Sanjay

# Chapter 1: The First Morning

The first morning is the morning after the funeral. The first morning is when the world expects you to start the new life. The first morning is when you realize you do not know how.

This chapter is for the first morning. This chapter is for what to expect. This chapter is for what to do.

## What the First Morning Is

The first morning is not a metaphor. The first morning is a real thing. The first morning is the moment you wake up — in your own bed, in the house you shared with your spouse — and realize that the person is not there.

The first morning is a moment of recognition. The first morning is when the body finally understands what the mind has been avoiding. The first morning is when the brain stops buffering the loss and the loss arrives, full force, in your chest.

The first morning is not when you cry. The first morning is when you cannot cry. The first morning is when the tears are too small for the loss. The first morning is when you lie in the bed, in the dark, and you breathe, and the breathing is all you can do.

The first morning is the beginning. Not the beginning of the new life. The beginning of the long walk. The first morning is the first step on a path that will take years to walk. The first morning is the first step that you do not have to walk alone.

# What the First Morning Feels Like

The first morning feels like a thousand things at once. The first morning feels like:

Shock. The shock that is finally real. The shock that has been buffered by the funeral, by the family, by the arrangements, by the adrenaline. The shock that arrives in the quiet of the morning, when there is no one to perform for, no one to be strong for, no one to organize for.

Numbness. The numbness that is not cold. The numbness that is the body's way of protecting itself from the full force of the loss. The numbness that will not last forever, but that may last for weeks, and that is normal.

Disbelief. The disbelief that the spouse is really gone. The disbelief that the body you held is not in the next room. The disbelief that the voice you heard is not going to call your name.

Absence. The absence of the small things. The absence of the sound of the breathing. The absence of the smell of the coffee they made. The absence of the weight of them on the other side of the bed. The absence is the loudest sound you have ever heard.

Grief. The grief that is not yet a wave. The grief that is the ocean. The grief that is underneath the shock, the numbness, the disbelief, the absence. The grief that will, eventually, become waves. The grief that will, eventually, have a shape.

The first morning feels like all of this. The first morning feels like more than you can hold. The first morning feels like you are not going to survive it.

You are going to survive it. Not because you are strong. Because the body is designed to survive. The

body will carry you through the first morning, and the second morning, and the hundredth morning. The body knows what to do. The body just needs you to let it do it.

## **What to Do in the First Morning**

The first morning is not the morning to plan. The first morning is not the morning to make decisions. The first morning is the morning to do only what is necessary.

The first morning is the morning to do these three things:

### **1. Get out of bed.**

The bed is a dangerous place on the first morning. The bed is the place where the loss is freshest. The bed is the place where the grief is sharpest. The bed is also the place where you can stay for hours, days, weeks.

The bed is not your friend on the first morning. The bed is a trap.

Get out of the bed. Stand up. Walk to the window. Open the curtain. Look at the day. The day is still here. The world is still here. The day and the world are waiting for you.

### **2. Drink water.**

The body is dehydrated. The body has been through trauma. The body needs water. Drink a glass of water. Drink another glass of water. The water is not a metaphor. The water is medicine.

If you can eat something, eat something. Toast, soup, fruit, anything. The body needs fuel. The body will not let you grieve if the body is starving. Feed the body.

### **3. Tell someone.**

You are not alone. There is someone — a friend, a family member, a counselor, a hotline, a neighbor, a priest, a stranger on the phone — who needs to know how you are.

Tell them. Tell them: "My spouse died. I am alone. I am not okay. Can you come?"

The telling is the first step. The telling is what makes the loss real in the company of another human being. The telling is what begins the work of carrying the grief together.

If you do not have someone to tell, call one of the numbers in the resources at the back of this book. The numbers are 24/7. The numbers are free. The numbers are for you.

## **What Not to Do in the First Morning**

The first morning is also not the morning to do many things. The first morning is the morning to NOT do:

- Do not try to plan the funeral. The funeral home will help. The family will help. A friend will help. The planning can wait.
- Do not try to make decisions about the house, the money, the future. The decisions can wait. The decisions will be clearer in a month, in three months, in a year.
- Do not try to "be strong." Being strong is not what the morning is for. The morning is for being honest. The morning is for being a person who has just lost a spouse.
- Do not try to "move on." Moving on is not what the morning is for. The morning is for being present. The morning is for being with the loss.

- Do not try to make sense of it. The loss does not make sense. The loss will not make sense for a long time. Trying to make sense of it will not help. Being with the not-making-sense is what helps.

## **The First Morning Is Not the Last**

The first morning is hard. The first morning is also not the last. The first morning is the beginning of a long walk.

The first morning will be followed by the second morning, and the third morning, and the hundredth morning. The mornings will be different. The mornings will get, slowly, slowly, slightly easier. The grief will not go away. The grief will become more familiar. The grief will become, over time, a part of you — a heavy part, but a part you can carry.

The first morning is the morning you will remember for the rest of your life. The first morning is the morning that will, eventually, become a chapter in the story of your survival. The first morning is the morning you will look back on and say: that was the morning. That was the morning it became real. That was the morning I began.

You are beginning. You are surviving the beginning. You are not alone.

The next chapter is about the body — the body that remains, the body that has to keep going, the body that has to be cared for, even when you do not want to care for it.

But for now, just get through this morning.

You are doing it. You are surviving it. You are The Survivor.

# Chapter 2: The Body That Remains

The body remains. Your body. The body that was holding the medication schedule, the doctor's appointments, the family schedule, the work schedule, the fear. The body that held the spouse. The body that held on for months, for years. The body that survived.

The body remains. And the body is exhausted. The body is more exhausted than you have ever been. The body has been running on adrenaline and love and fear and duty for so long that the body does not know what to do without them.

This chapter is for the body. This chapter is for the body that has to be cared for, even when the body's owner does not want to care for it. This chapter is for the body that has to survive.

## The Caregiver's Body

You have been a caregiver. For months. For years. Maybe for a long time. Maybe for a long goodbye. The caregiving took a toll on the body that you may not have noticed while you were doing it.

The caregiving took a toll in the form of:

- Sleep deprivation. The caregiving years often involve interrupted sleep, sleeping in chairs, sleeping with one ear open for the call button. The body is operating on years of sleep debt.
- Chronic stress. The caregiving years involve constant vigilance, constant decision-making, constant fear. The body is bathed in stress hormones for years. The body pays the price in inflammation, in immune suppression, in

cardiovascular strain.

- Neglect of own health. The caregiving years involve putting the spouse's health first. Your own appointments get skipped. Your own medications get missed. Your own exercise, your own diet, your own self-care, get deprioritized.
- Emotional suppression. The caregiving years involve being strong for the spouse, for the family, for the medical team. The body learns to hold the tears, to push down the fear, to perform the role of "the strong one." The body pays the price in tension, in pain, in chronic illness.
- Grief anticipatory. The caregiving years involve knowing, intellectually, that the spouse is going to die. The body begins to grieve before the death. The body is already tired before the death happens.

By the time the spouse dies, the body is already worn. The body is already exhausted. The body is already in a state of depletion. The death is not the start of the body's exhaustion. The death is the next chapter in a long story of the body's wear.

## **What the Body Needs Now**

The body needs to be cared for. Now. Not later. Now. The body has been the last priority for too long. The body needs to be the first priority.

The body needs:

Sleep.

The body needs 7-9 hours of sleep per night. The body may not be able to sleep for that long at first. The body may not be able to sleep at all at first. But the body needs to try.

If you cannot sleep:

- Talk to your doctor. The doctor can prescribe sleep medication for a short time. The medication is not a long-term solution. The medication is a bridge to better sleep.
- Avoid screens before bed. The light from screens suppresses melatonin, the hormone that helps you sleep.
- Avoid alcohol. The alcohol may make you feel sleepy, but the alcohol disrupts the sleep cycle. The alcohol makes the sleep worse, not better.
- Create a bedtime routine. The routine signals to the body that it is time to sleep. Bath, book, bed. The routine is a gift to the body.
- Get up at the same time every day. The wake time, even more than the bedtime, sets the body's clock. Get up at the same time, even if you did not sleep well.

Nutrition.

The body needs real food. Not comfort food. Not junk food. Real food. Protein, vegetables, fruit, whole grains. The food is fuel for the grief. The food is medicine for the body.

If you cannot eat:

- Eat small meals. The body may not be able to handle a large meal. Small meals, every 2-3 hours, may be easier.
- Drink your calories. Smoothies, soups, protein shakes. The liquid nutrition is easier on the body.
- Eat with someone. Eating alone is hard. Eating with a friend, a family member, a neighbor, is easier. The eating is a connection, not just a nutrition.

## Movement.

The body needs to move. The body has been still for too long — sitting in the hospital chair, sitting in the waiting room, sitting by the bed. The body needs to move.

The body does not need a marathon. The body needs a walk. A 10-minute walk, every day. The walk is for the body. The walk is also for the mind. The walk gets the body out of the house, into the air, into the world.

If you cannot walk:

- Stand up and sit down 10 times. The simple movement is enough.
- Stretch. The stretching is a gift to the body.
- Dance. The dancing is a gift to the soul.

## Medical care.

The body needs medical care. The body has been neglecting its own care. The body needs to see a doctor. The body needs a check-up. The body needs to have its blood pressure checked, its cholesterol checked, its sleep assessed, its medications reviewed.

Make an appointment with your primary care doctor. Make the appointment in the first month. The appointment is not optional. The appointment is part of the survival.

## Mental health care.

The body needs mental health care. The body has been through trauma. The body is grieving. The body may be developing depression, anxiety, PTSD. The body needs a therapist, a counselor, a support group, a hotline.

The mental health care is not a sign of weakness. The mental health care is a sign of wisdom. The mental

health care is what helps the body process the loss.

Make an appointment with a therapist. Make an appointment in the first month. The appointment is not optional. The appointment is part of the survival.

## **The Body as Memory**

The body holds memory. The body holds the memory of the spouse. The body holds the memory of the caregiving. The body holds the memory in the form of:

- Scents. The smell of the spouse's perfume, the smell of the hospital room, the smell of the medication. The scents can come back at any time — in the grocery store, in the bedroom, in the car. The scents can be overwhelming. The scents are also the body's way of keeping the spouse alive.
- Sounds. The sound of the spouse's voice, the sound of the breathing, the sound of the beeping monitor. The sounds can come back at any time — in a crowd, in a quiet room, in a song on the radio. The sounds are also the body's way of keeping the spouse alive.
- Touch. The feel of the spouse's hand, the feel of the spouse's skin, the feel of the spouse's body in the bed. The touch can come back at any time — when you reach for the empty side of the bed, when you hold the grandchild, when you pet the dog. The touch is also the body's way of keeping the spouse alive.
- Movements. The act of brushing your teeth, the act of setting the table for two, the act of doing the medication schedule that no longer exists. The movements can come back at any time — in the morning, in the evening, in the middle of the night. The movements are also the body's way of keeping

the spouse alive.

The body is a memorial. The body is a living memorial. The body carries the spouse in the form of memory. The body will carry the memory for the rest of your life. The memory is a gift, even when the memory is also a pain.

## **A Word About the Sleep**

The sleep is the hardest part. The sleep is when the body is most alone. The sleep is when the body is most vulnerable. The sleep is when the spouse is most missed.

The sleep is also necessary. The body cannot survive without sleep. The body cannot grieve without sleep. The body cannot heal without sleep.

The sleep will not come easily. The sleep will be broken. The sleep will be full of dreams — sometimes the spouse is alive in the dreams, sometimes the spouse is dying, sometimes the spouse is just there, sitting in the chair, watching you. The dreams are not real. The dreams are the brain's way of processing the loss. The dreams are a sign of healing, not a sign of illness.

The sleep will come, eventually, more peacefully. The sleep will not be perfect. The sleep will be the sleep of a person who has lost a spouse — a sleep that is sometimes heavy, sometimes light, sometimes broken, sometimes whole. The sleep will be enough.

## **A Word About the Eating**

The eating is also hard. The eating is when the body is most reminded of the spouse. The eating is when the chair across the table is empty. The eating is when the routine of cooking for two is broken.

The eating will also come, eventually, more peacefully. The eating will become the eating of a person who is feeding themselves. The eating will be a small act of self-care, repeated three times a day. The eating will be enough.

## **A Word About the Body Itself**

The body that remains is not the body that was. The body that remains is the body that has been through the caregiving and the death. The body that remains is the body that is tired, that is grieving, that is learning to be without the spouse.

The body that remains is also the body that survived. The body that remains is the body that is still here. The body that remains is the body that is going to walk the long walk. The body that remains is the body that is going to be The Survivor.

You are The Survivor. Your body is The Survivor's body. Your body is the vehicle for the long walk. Your body is worth caring for.

The next chapter is about the funeral — the funeral nobody wants, the funeral that has to be planned, the funeral that is the last official act of the caregiving years.

But for now, take care of the body. Sleep if you can. Eat if you can. Move if you can. The body is the foundation. The body is the home. The body is what you have.

# **Chapter 3: The Funeral Nobody Wants**

The funeral is the last official act of the caregiving years. The funeral is the ceremony that marks the end. The funeral is the thing nobody wants to plan. The funeral is the thing that has to be done anyway.

This chapter is for the funeral. This chapter is for the planning, the ceremony, the aftermath. This chapter is for the part of the journey that the caregivers do not talk about.

## **Why the Funeral Is Hard**

The funeral is hard for a specific reason. The funeral is hard because the funeral requires you to perform. The funeral requires you to be the strong one. The funeral requires you to receive the condolences, to thank the people for coming, to make the decisions about the music and the flowers and the eulogy.

The funeral is hard because the funeral is the opposite of what you feel. The funeral requires you to be the host. The funeral requires you to be the greeter. The funeral requires you to be the person who is in control.

You are not in control. You have not been in control for a long time. The illness was not in your control. The death was not in your control. The funeral is one more thing that is not in your control.

The funeral is also hard because the funeral is the last time you will do something as a couple. The funeral is the last time you will be in the same room as your spouse. The funeral is the last time you will see the body. The funeral is the last goodbye.

The last goodbye is hard. The last goodbye is the hardest goodbye of all the goodbyes.

## **Planning the Funeral**

The funeral does not have to be perfect. The funeral does not have to be elaborate. The funeral does not have to be what anyone else thinks it should be. The funeral has to be what you and your spouse would have wanted.

The funeral is a chance to honor the spouse. The funeral is a chance to celebrate the life. The funeral is a chance to gather the community. The funeral is a chance to start the public grieving.

The funeral is also a chance to NOT do certain things. The funeral is a chance to skip the parts that do not feel right. The funeral is a chance to do only the parts that feel right. The funeral is yours to design.

Here are some decisions you will have to make:

Burial or cremation?

This decision was probably already made — either by the spouse before they died, or by the family in the moment. If the decision was not made, you will have to make it now.

The decision is not easy. The decision is also not a moral decision. The decision is a practical decision. The spouse's body will be cared for in some way. The way you choose is the way that respects the spouse, the family, the budget, the tradition.

Religious or secular?

The funeral can be religious. The funeral can be secular. The funeral can be both. The funeral is for the spouse, not for the religion. The funeral should reflect

the spouse's beliefs, or your beliefs if the spouse did not have a specific belief, or the family's beliefs.

Small or large?

The funeral can be small. The funeral can be large. The funeral can be only family. The funeral can be the whole community. The funeral should be the size that feels right. The size should not be about who you "have to" invite. The size should be about who you "want to" have there.

Eulogy or no eulogy?

Someone should speak. The speaking is the honoring. The speaking can be done by you, or by a friend, or by a family member, or by multiple people. The speaking should be true. The speaking should be from the heart. The speaking does not have to be eloquent. The speaking just has to be honest.

## **The Day of the Funeral**

The day of the funeral is a strange day. The day of the funeral is the day that you have to be on. The day of the funeral is the day that the community is gathered. The day of the funeral is the day that the ceremony happens.

The day of the funeral will go by in a blur. The day of the funeral is not the day to feel the feelings. The day of the funeral is the day to do the actions. The feelings will come later. The feelings are for the days after.

Here is what to expect on the day of the funeral:

The morning is a fog. You will wake up and not be able to believe the funeral is today. You will go through the motions of getting dressed, of eating something, of getting to the venue. The motions will be on autopilot. The motions are normal.

The arrival is a shock. When you arrive at the venue and see the flowers, the casket, the people, the reality will hit. The reality will hit hard. The reality is that this is real. The reality is that the spouse is in the casket. The reality is that you are about to say goodbye.

The ceremony is a blur. The ceremony will pass in what feels like minutes and what feels like hours. You will not remember most of it. You will remember small moments — a particular song, a particular prayer, a particular look from a friend. The small moments are what will stay with you.

The reception is a relief. After the ceremony, the reception is a chance to breathe. The reception is a chance to eat something, to drink something, to talk to people about the spouse, to share stories, to laugh, to cry, to be with the community. The reception is also exhausting. The reception is the last event of the funeral.

The going home is the hardest part. When the funeral is over and you go home, the house is empty. The funeral is over. The community has gone. You are alone with the loss. The going home is the moment when the reality becomes real.

## **After the Funeral**

The days after the funeral are the days when the community starts to drift. The casseroles stop arriving. The phone stops ringing. The people who said "call me if you need anything" are no longer there.

The days after the funeral are the days when the grief becomes real. The grief was buffered by the funeral, by the family, by the community. The grief is no longer buffered. The grief is now yours, alone, in the quiet

house.

The days after the funeral are also the days when the healing can begin. The healing cannot begin while the funeral is being planned. The healing cannot begin while the community is gathered. The healing begins when the funeral is over and the quiet returns.

The healing is slow. The healing is uneven. The healing is full of setbacks. The healing is also real.

The next chapter is about the house that was theirs — the house that is now yours, alone, the house that has to be navigated, the house that has to be lived in, the house that has to be, eventually, made into a home again.

## **A Word About the Spouse's Belongings**

One of the hardest things after the funeral is the question of the spouse's belongings. The clothes in the closet. The books on the shelf. The photos on the wall. The tools in the garage. The medications in the cabinet. The toothbrush in the holder.

The belongings are not the spouse. The belongings are the things the spouse used. The belongings are the evidence of the spouse's life. The belongings are also the reminders of the absence.

The belongings do not have to be dealt with immediately. The belongings can stay where they are for weeks, for months. The belongings are not going anywhere. The belongings will be there when you are ready.

When you are ready to deal with the belongings, the dealing can be done slowly, in small pieces. The dealing does not have to be done in a day. The dealing

does not have to be done alone. The dealing can be done with a friend, a family member, a support group.

Some belongings will be easy. Some will be hard. Some will be impossible for a long time. All of it is normal. All of it is part of the grieving. All of it is part of The Survivor's work.

## **A Word About Telling People**

After the funeral, you will have to tell people. You will have to tell the neighbors. You will have to tell the people you have not seen in years. You will have to tell the people who knew your spouse. You will have to tell the people who did not know your spouse.

The telling is exhausting. The telling is also a gift. The telling is the way the world learns that your spouse is gone. The telling is the way the world learns that you are now alone.

The telling can be done in whatever way feels easiest. A phone call. A text. An email. A social media post. A letter. A conversation in the grocery store. The telling does not have to be the same with everyone. The telling can be brief. The telling can be detailed. The telling is yours to do.

The next chapter is about the house. The next chapter is about the home. The next chapter is about the place where the memory lives.

# Chapter 4: The House That Was Theirs

The house was theirs. The house is now yours, alone. The house is the place where the memory lives. The house is also the place where the new life has to be built.

This chapter is for the house. This chapter is for the navigating. This chapter is for the parts of the house that hurt and the parts that help.

## The House as Memory

The house is full of memory. Every room. Every piece of furniture. Every object. The house is a museum of the marriage.

The bedroom. The bed is made the way they made it. The side of the bed where they slept is empty. The pillow is still there. The blanket is still there. The nightstand is still there. The nightstand has their reading glasses, their water glass, their medication, their book. The bedroom is the place where the absence is sharpest.

The bathroom. The toothbrush is in the holder. The towel is on the rack. The shampoo is in the shower. The comb is on the counter. The bathroom is the place where the small intimacies of the marriage are most visible.

The kitchen. The chair where they sat is empty. The coffee mug they used is in the cabinet. The cookbook they used is on the shelf. The kitchen is the place where the meals you no longer cook for two are prepared.

The living room. The chair where they read is empty. The book they were reading is on the table. The TV remote is on the armrest. The living room is the place where the evenings you used to spend together are now spent alone.

The house is full of memory. The house is also the place where you live. The house is the place where you have to keep living. The memory and the living have to coexist.

## **The First Weeks in the House**

The first weeks in the house are the hardest. The first weeks in the house are when the absence is most acute. The first weeks in the house are when the house feels like a museum of the marriage.

The first weeks in the house are also the weeks when the spouse's absence is most constant. The spouse is not in the next room. The spouse is not in the bed. The spouse is not in the kitchen. The spouse is not in the bathroom. The spouse is not in the chair. The spouse is not anywhere in the house. The spouse is only in the memory.

The first weeks in the house are the weeks when the small things hurt most. The first weeks in the house are when you reach for the phone to call the spouse and remember there is no one to call. The first weeks in the house are when you set the table for two and then have to put one place setting away. The first weeks in the house are when you hear a sound and think it is the spouse, and then realize it is the house settling.

The first weeks in the house are also the weeks when the small things help most. The first weeks in the house are when the friend who comes by with soup is

a gift. The first weeks in the house are when the neighbor who knocks on the door to check on you is a gift. The first weeks in the house are when the family member who stays with you for a week is a gift. The small things are the big things. The small things are what get you through.

## **What to Do in the First Weeks**

The first weeks in the house are the weeks to do only what is necessary. The first weeks in the house are not the weeks to reorganize, to redecorate, to "make the house your own." The first weeks in the house are the weeks to do what you can.

Stay in the house if you can.

The house is hard. The house is also home. The house is the place where the memory lives. The house is the place where the new life can be built. Staying in the house is hard. Staying in the house is also, often, the right thing to do.

If you can stay in the house, stay. If you cannot stay in the house, that is also okay. There is no rule that says the widowed caregiver has to stay in the house. The decision is yours.

Ask for help if you need it.

The house is a lot. The house has rooms, and bills, and maintenance, and a yard, and a roof, and a thousand small things that the spouse used to help with. The house is a lot for one person.

Ask for help. Ask the neighbors. Ask the family. Ask the friends. Ask the church. Ask the community. The help is not weakness. The help is wisdom. The help is what gets you through the first weeks.

Move slowly.

The first weeks are not the weeks to make big decisions. The first weeks are not the weeks to sell the house, to give away the belongings, to change the locks. The first weeks are the weeks to move slowly. The decisions will be clearer in a month, in three months, in a year. The decisions can wait.

## **The Spouse's Side of the Bed**

The spouse's side of the bed is the hardest part of the house. The spouse's side of the bed is the place where the absence is most physical. The spouse's side of the bed is the place where the body most wants the spouse.

The spouse's side of the bed can be left as it is for a while. The spouse's side of the bed can be the place where the memory of the spouse lives. The spouse's side of the bed is not a problem to be solved. The spouse's side of the bed is a grief to be carried.

When you are ready, the spouse's side of the bed can be changed. The spouse's side of the bed can be made into a reading nook. The spouse's side of the bed can be made into a place for the grandchild when they visit. The spouse's side of the bed can be made into anything you want it to be. The making is yours. The making is not now. The making is when you are ready.

## **The Chair Where They Sat**

The chair where they sat is the other hard part of the house. The chair where they sat is the place where the spouse used to be during the evenings. The chair where they sat is the place where you can almost see them, even though they are not there.

The chair where they sat can be left as it is for a while. The chair where they sat can be the place where the

memory lives. The chair where they sat is not a problem to be solved. The chair where they sat is a grief to be carried.

When you are ready, the chair where they sat can be moved. The chair where they sat can be replaced. The chair where they sat can be made into anything you want it to be. The making is yours. The making is not now. The making is when you are ready.

## **The Clothes in the Closet**

The clothes in the closet are the third hard part. The clothes in the closet are the physical presence of the spouse. The clothes in the closet smell like the spouse, even after the spouse is gone. The clothes in the closet are the things the spouse used to wear.

The clothes in the closet do not have to be dealt with now. The clothes in the closet do not have to be given away now. The clothes in the closet can stay where they are. The clothes in the closet are a memorial, even if they are not yet a memorial you are ready to make.

When you are ready, the clothes in the closet can be given away. The clothes in the closet can be given to a family member, to a charity, to a friend. The giving is not a betrayal. The giving is a way of honoring the spouse by letting the clothes go to someone who needs them.

When you are ready, the clothes in the closet can also be kept. Some widowed caregivers keep a few items of the spouse's clothing. The keeping is a private thing. The keeping is a way of keeping the spouse close.

There is no right way to do the clothes. There is only your way.

## **The House as Future**

The house was the past. The house is also the future. The house is the place where the new life will be built. The house is the place where the next chapter will be lived.

The house will change. The house will not be the same as it was when the spouse was alive. The house will be, in many ways, a different house. The house will be a house that is lived in by one person, not two. The house will be a house that is shaped by one person's choices, not two people's compromises.

The house will also, in many ways, be the same. The house will have the same walls, the same windows, the same rooms. The house will have the same sun in the morning. The house will have the same stars at night. The house will have the same garden, the same trees, the same birds.

The house will be a place of memory. The house will also be a place of new memory. The house will hold both. The house is large enough to hold both. The house is your house. The house is your future.

The next chapter is about the identity that was the spouse's. The next chapter is about the part of you that was the spouse's spouse. The next chapter is about who you are when you are no longer the spouse of someone.

But for now, just be in the house. The house is the place. The house is the home. The house is yours.

# Chapter 5: The Identity That Was Wife/Husband

You were a wife. You were a husband. You were a spouse. For years, for decades, the word "wife" or "husband" was part of how you introduced yourself. "I'm so-and-so. This is my wife, Jane." Or "I'm so-and-so. This is my husband, Tom."

You are no longer a wife. You are no longer a husband. The word has not changed in your mouth, but the meaning has. The word "wife" or "husband" now refers to a person who is no longer here. The word now describes an absence, not a presence.

This chapter is for the identity. This chapter is for the person you were when you were a spouse. This chapter is for the person you are becoming now that you are not a spouse.

## The Spouse as Identity

The spouse is not just a person. The spouse is part of your identity. The spouse is part of how you see yourself. The spouse is part of how the world sees you. The spouse is part of the story you tell about yourself.

When someone asks you "Who are you?", the answer used to include the spouse. "I am a wife." "I am a husband." "I am a partner." "I am the person who takes care of so-and-so." The answer was woven into the identity.

When the spouse dies, the answer changes. The answer is no longer "I am a wife." The answer is no longer "I am a husband." The answer is now "I am a person whose spouse died." The answer is now an absence. The answer is now a loss.

The loss of the identity is a specific kind of loss. The loss of the identity is not the same as the loss of the person. The loss of the identity is the loss of the part of yourself that was defined by the relationship. The loss of the identity is the loss of the role, the daily rhythm, the sense of purpose that came from being part of a couple.

The loss of the identity can be as painful as the loss of the person. The loss of the identity can also be more confusing, because the identity is invisible. The person is gone, and the loss of the person is recognized. The identity is also gone, and the loss of the identity is not recognized. The world grieves the person. The world does not grieve the identity.

You have to grieve the identity yourself.

## **What the Spouse Did for You**

The spouse did more than be your partner. The spouse did things for you that you may not have recognized as gifts. The spouse did things for you that were so woven into the daily routine that you did not see them as acts of love.

The spouse probably:

- Made you feel seen. The spouse was the one person in the world who knew you most completely. The spouse was the one who noticed when you were tired, when you were sad, when you were happy, when you were pretending. The spouse was the one who saw you when you could not see yourself.
- Made you feel valued. The spouse was the one who told you that you were doing a good job, that you were a good parent, that you were a good person, that you were loved. The spouse was the

one who validated you in the ways that mattered most.

- Made you feel needed. The spouse was the one who depended on you. The spouse was the one who asked for your help, your opinion, your presence. The spouse was the one who made you feel like you had a role.
- Made you feel held. The spouse was the one who held you when you were sad, who held you when you were scared, who held you when you were alone. The spouse was the one who made the world feel less frightening.
- Made you feel accompanied. The spouse was the one who went through life with you. The spouse was the one who saw the sunrise with you, who saw the movie with you, who saw the grandchild's first step with you. The spouse was the one who made the world feel less lonely.

When the spouse dies, all of these gifts stop. The seeing stops. The valuing stops. The needing stops. The holding stops. The accompanying stops.

The stopping is a loss. The stopping is also a kind of freedom, eventually. The freedom is not immediate. The freedom is something that emerges, slowly, over the years. The freedom is the freedom to be seen in new ways, by new people, in new relationships. The freedom is also the freedom to see yourself, finally, on your own.

But first, the loss.

# **The Identity Crisis**

The identity crisis after the death of a spouse is real. The identity crisis is the experience of not knowing who you are. The identity crisis is the experience of looking in the mirror and not recognizing the person looking back. The identity crisis is the experience of being asked "What do you do?" and not knowing how to answer, because what you did was the caregiving, and the caregiving is over.

The identity crisis is not a clinical crisis. The identity crisis is not a breakdown. The identity crisis is a normal part of the widowed caregiver's journey. The identity crisis is what happens when the role that defined you is gone.

The identity crisis has a name in the grief literature. The name is "disenfranchised grief" — the grief for a loss that is not socially recognized. The identity crisis is also a kind of disenfranchised grief. The grief for the role is not socially recognized. The grief for the daily rhythm is not socially recognized. The grief for the "I am a wife" or "I am a husband" is not socially recognized.

You have to grieve the identity yourself. The world will not grieve it for you. The world will expect you to "find yourself" or "discover who you are now" or "move on and find a new identity." The world will not understand that the new identity cannot be forced. The new identity emerges, slowly, when you are ready.

## **What Helps with the Identity**

The identity heals. The identity heals slowly, and unevenly, but it heals. Here are some things that help with the identity.

Give yourself time.

The identity is not going to be rebuilt in a month. The identity is not going to be rebuilt in a year. The identity is going to be rebuilt over the rest of your life. The rebuilding is slow. The rebuilding is also real.

Keep doing things that are yours.

The identity was partly defined by the caregiving. The identity was also defined by other things — your work, your hobbies, your friendships, your faith, your community. The other things are still yours. The other things can still define you. The other things can be the foundation of the new identity.

Try new things.

The new identity is not just the old identity minus the spouse. The new identity is something new. The new identity includes things you have not tried yet. The new identity includes hobbies you have not pursued, friendships you have not made, places you have not been.

Trying new things is a way of building the new identity. The trying does not have to be big. The trying can be small — a new recipe, a new class, a new walk, a new book. The trying is the building.

Let the new identity emerge.

The new identity is not something you can plan. The new identity is something that emerges, slowly, from the daily practice of being alive. The new identity will surprise you. The new identity will include parts of the old identity and parts of the new. The new identity will be you, but a different you. The new identity will be The Survivor.

## **A Word About Being Asked How You Are**

You will be asked how you are. You will be asked many times, by many people, in many contexts. The question "How are you?" will become a question that requires a decision.

The decision is whether to tell the truth or not. The truth is hard. The truth is "I am not okay. My spouse died. I am grieving. I am learning to live." The truth is not what most people are ready to hear.

You can tell the truth to the people who can hold it. You can tell the truth to the close friends, the family, the therapist, the support group. The truth is a gift to them, and to you, when it is told to the people who can receive it.

You can also not tell the truth. You can say "I am okay" or "I am getting there" or "I am taking it one day at a time" to the people who cannot hold the truth. The not-telling is not a lie. The not-telling is a way of protecting yourself and the other person.

The decision is yours. The decision can be different with different people. The decision can change day by day.

## **A Word About the Word "Widow" or "Widower"**

You will be called a widow or a widower. The word will be applied to you, by others and by yourself. The word is the word for what you are now.

The word can feel wrong. The word can feel like a label that is being put on you without your permission. The word can feel like a thing that is happening to

you, not a thing that is part of you.

The word is also the truth. The word is what you are now. The word does not have to define you. The word is just the word for what has happened. The word is the doorway, not the destination.

The word will become more familiar. The word will become, eventually, a word you can use without flinching. The word will become a word that describes the new you, not the old you. The word will be a word that gives you access to a community — the community of widows and widowers, the community of people who know what you are going through because they have been there.

The community is a gift. The word is the door to the community. The word is worth using.

The next chapter is about the friends who do not know what to say. The next chapter is about the awkwardness, the distance, the disappearance, the people who do not show up. The next chapter is about the people who do show up. The next chapter is about the community that does form, eventually, if you let it.

# **Chapter 6: The Friends Who Don't Know What to Say**

You will lose friends. The friends will not all be lost. The friends will be sorted. The friends will reveal themselves, in the months after the death, as the friends who are still there and the friends who are not. The sorting is one of the most painful parts of the widowed caregiver's journey. The sorting is also one of the most clarifying parts.

This chapter is for the sorting. This chapter is for the friends who show up, the friends who do not show up, and the new friends who appear.

## **The Friends Who Disappear**

You will lose friends. You will lose friends you expected to be there. You will lose friends who were at the funeral. You will lose friends who said "Call me if you need anything." You will lose friends who were your couple friends, your dinner party friends, your holiday friends.

The friends will disappear for a reason. The friends will disappear because they do not know what to say. The friends will disappear because your loss is too big for them. The friends will disappear because your loss is a mirror for their own mortality. The friends will disappear because they do not know how to be around a person who is grieving.

The disappearance is not personal. The disappearance is about the friends' own fears, not about you. The disappearance is about the friends' own discomfort with death, with grief, with the reality that the people

they love can die.

The disappearance is also painful. The disappearance is one of the most painful parts of the widowed caregiver's journey. The disappearance is the loss of the social network that was built around the couple. The disappearance is the loss of the dinner parties, the holiday gatherings, the weekend visits. The disappearance is the loss of the community.

The disappearance is also clarifying. The disappearance shows you who your real friends are. The disappearance shows you who was there for the marriage, not for you. The disappearance shows you who was there for the couple, not for the person.

The friends who disappear are not bad people. The friends who disappear are just people who could not hold the loss. The friends who disappear are people who will, often, come back — a year, two years, five years later — with a sheepish email or a hesitant phone call. The friends who come back are welcome. The friends who do not come back are also okay. The friendships that are meant to survive the loss will survive. The friendships that are not meant to survive will not. The letting go is part of the grieving.

## **The Friends Who Stay**

You will have friends who stay. The friends who stay will be the ones who are surprised by the staying, sometimes. The friends who stay will be the ones who say "I don't know what to say, but I'm here." The friends who stay will be the ones who show up, with food, with a hug, with a hand on the shoulder, with a willingness to sit in the silence.

The friends who stay are the ones who understand that the loss is not a problem to be solved. The friends

who stay are the ones who understand that the loss is a reality to be accompanied. The friends who stay are the ones who do not try to fix the grief. The friends who stay are the ones who are willing to be with the grief.

The friends who stay are also the ones who are the most important people in the new life. The friends who stay are the ones who will be the dinner party guests, the holiday companions, the weekend visitors. The friends who stay are the ones who will be the family of choice, the community of choice, the people who will be there for the new life.

The friends who stay deserve to be thanked. The friends who stay deserve to be cherished. The friends who stay are the gift that comes out of the loss.

## **The Awkward Things People Say**

People will say awkward things. People will say things that hurt. People will say things that are well-intentioned but completely wrong. People will say things that make you want to scream.

Here are some of the things people will say, and some thoughts on how to respond:

- "They're in a better place." The person is not in a better place. The person is in the ground, or in the urn, or in your memory. The person is not in a better place. You can say, "I appreciate you trying to help. I don't believe that, but I appreciate the kindness." Or you can say nothing. The saying nothing is also a valid response.
- "Time heals all wounds." Time does not heal all wounds. Time does not bring back the dead. Time helps you carry the wound, but the wound does not heal. The wound becomes, eventually, a scar. The

scar is part of you. The scar is not the same as healed. You can say, "Time is helping me learn to carry it." Or you can say nothing.

- "You should move on." You should not move on. You should move forward, eventually. But "move on" is a phrase that implies the loss is something to get over. The loss is not something to get over. The loss is something to live with. You can say, "I am moving forward, in my own way, in my own time." Or you can say nothing.

- "At least they're not suffering anymore." The spouse may not be suffering anymore. The spouse may be at peace. The spouse's not suffering does not make your suffering less. Your suffering is real. Your suffering deserves to be acknowledged. You can say, "I am glad they're at peace. I am still learning to be at peace myself." Or you can say nothing.

- "I know how you feel." Unless the person has also lost a spouse, the person does not know how you feel. The person may have lost a parent, a sibling, a child, a friend. The losses are real, but the losses are not the same. The loss of a spouse is a specific kind of loss. You can say, "Thank you for understanding as much as you can." Or you can say nothing.

- "You look great." You may not look great. You may look exhausted, depleted, hollow. The person is trying to compliment you, but the compliment is about the wrong thing. The person should be asking how you are, not how you look. You can say, "Thank you. I am doing the best I can." Or you can say nothing.

The awkward things are part of the journey. The awkward things are not going to stop. The awkward

things are an opportunity to practice the new skill of responding to the loss with grace. The graceful responding does not mean the awkward things do not hurt. The graceful responding means you have a choice in how you respond. The choice is yours.

## **The New Friends**

You will make new friends. The new friends will not replace the old friends. The new friends will be different. The new friends will be the friends who understand the loss because they have been through it.

The new friends will come from:

- Grief support groups. The grief support groups are the places where the new friends live. The grief support groups are the places where the people who understand the loss gather. The grief support groups are the places where you can say "I am not okay" and the people will not run away.
- Widow and widower communities. The widow and widower communities are the places where the new friends are organized. The communities are online and in person. The communities are religious and secular. The communities are local and national. The communities are for you.
- Casual connections. The new friends will also come from the most unexpected places — the grocery store, the gym, the library, the park, the doctor's waiting room. The new friends will be the people who are also alone, who are also widowed, who are also looking for connection. The new friends will be the people you meet when you start doing things again.

- The old friends who surprise you. Some of the old friends will surprise you. The old friends will come back. The old friends will reach out in ways you did not expect. The old friends will become the new friends, in a deeper way. The old friends who surprise you are a gift.

The new friends are not a replacement for the spouse. The new friends are a complement to the memory of the spouse. The new friends are the community that forms around the widowed caregiver, the community that holds the widowed caregiver, the community that helps the widowed caregiver survive.

## **A Word About Saying Yes**

You will be invited to things. You will be invited to dinner, to coffee, to a walk, to a class, to a movie, to a concert. The invitations will come. The invitations will be the work of the friends who are trying to keep you connected.

Say yes. Say yes even when you do not want to. Say yes even when you would rather stay home. Say yes even when you are tired, even when you are sad, even when you are not sure you can be in the company of others.

The saying yes is the work of rebuilding. The saying yes is the work of forming the new community. The saying yes is the work of being The Survivor.

The next chapter is about the grief that does not follow the stages. The next chapter is about the reality that the grief is not a clean progression from denial to acceptance. The next chapter is about the waves, and the unpredictability, and the way the grief works in real life.

# Chapter 7: The Grief That Doesn't Follow the Stages

You will be told that grief has stages. You will be told that you will go through denial, then anger, then bargaining, then depression, then acceptance. You will be told that the stages are predictable, that they are universal, that they are the way grief works.

The people who tell you this are wrong.

The grief does not follow the stages. The grief is not predictable. The grief is not universal. The grief is not a clean progression. The grief is messy, and complicated, and personal, and full of detours, and full of going back, and full of surprises.

This chapter is for the real grief. This chapter is for the grief that does not follow the stages. This chapter is for the grief that is, in fact, the work of The Survivor.

## The Kübler-Ross Myth

The "stages of grief" come from the work of Elisabeth Kübler-Ross, a Swiss-American psychiatrist who wrote a famous book called *On Death and Dying* in 1969. The book was about the dying, not the bereaved. The book described the five stages that dying people go through as they come to terms with their own death: denial, anger, bargaining, depression, acceptance.

The book was not about grief. The book was about dying. The book was about the people who are dying, not the people who are left behind.

But the book was misread. The book was misread as being about grief. The book was applied, by

well-meaning therapists and writers, to the people who are bereaved. The book became the standard model of grief. The book became the thing that everyone is told about grief.

The book is wrong about grief. The book is wrong because the grief is not a stage-based process. The grief is a wave-based process. The grief comes in waves. The waves are unpredictable. The waves are not the same. The waves do not follow a pattern.

You may have days when you feel acceptance. You may have days when you feel denial. You may have days when you feel all five stages in a single morning. You may have days when you feel none of the stages. You may have days when the grief is so overwhelming that the stages are irrelevant. You may have days when the grief is so absent that you wonder if you are really grieving at all.

The grief is not a stage. The grief is a wave. The waves will continue for the rest of your life. The waves will get smaller, eventually. The waves will not stop.

## **The Waves of Grief**

The waves of grief are not predictable. The waves of grief are not the same. The waves of grief are triggered by things you cannot anticipate.

The waves can be triggered by:

- Sights. The sight of a couple holding hands in the grocery store. The sight of an elderly man being pushed in a wheelchair. The sight of a chair that is the same color as the one the spouse used to sit in. The sight of a sunbeam that looks like the one that used to come through the bedroom window on Saturday mornings.

- Sounds. The sound of a song that was "your song." The sound of a name that is also the spouse's name. The sound of a laugh that reminds you of the spouse's laugh. The sound of the doorbell, which you used to think was the spouse coming home.
- Smells. The smell of the spouse's perfume or cologne. The smell of the hospital. The smell of the medication. The smell of a particular food the spouse used to make.
- Touches. The feel of the empty side of the bed. The feel of a handshake from a friend. The feel of a grandchild's hand. The feel of a fabric that the spouse used to wear.
- Tastes. The taste of a meal the spouse used to make. The taste of a wine the spouse used to drink. The taste of a dessert the spouse used to love.
- Memories. A memory that comes unbidden. A memory of a particular moment, a particular conversation, a particular joke. The memory can come at any time, in any place. The memory is the body keeping the spouse alive.

The waves can be triggered by anything. The waves can be triggered by something obvious. The waves can be triggered by something completely random. The waves do not give you warning. The waves arrive when they arrive.

# **The Things Nobody Tells You About Grief**

There are things about grief that nobody tells you. The things are not in the books. The things are not in the support groups. The things are the things you learn in the doing.

Here are some of the things nobody tells you:

You will forget the spouse, sometimes.

You will forget the spouse. You will forget to set a place for them. You will forget to call them. You will forget what they were like. You will forget a memory you used to know by heart. You will forget and you will be horrified by the forgetting, and you will be comforted by the forgetting, and you will feel guilty for the forgetting, all at once.

The forgetting is not a betrayal. The forgetting is a sign that the brain is trying to protect you. The brain cannot hold all of the memories all of the time. The brain lets some memories go so that other memories can be held. The forgetting is the brain's mercy.

When the memory comes back, the memory is a gift. When the memory does not come back, the memory is also okay. The memory does not have to be perfect. The memory is allowed to fade. The memory is allowed to evolve.

You will laugh, sometimes.

You will laugh. You will laugh at a joke, at a movie, at a friend's story, at your own mistake. The laugh will surprise you. The laugh will feel like a betrayal. The laugh will feel like you are being disloyal to the spouse.

The laugh is not a betrayal. The laugh is a sign of life. The laugh is the body's way of saying: I am still here. I am still capable of joy. The joy does not replace the grief. The joy is alongside the grief.

The laugh is allowed. The laugh is welcome. The laugh is the proof that you are still alive.

You will be angry.

You will be angry. You will be angry at the spouse for dying. You will be angry at the illness for taking them. You will be angry at the doctors for not saving them. You will be angry at God for letting it happen. You will be angry at yourself for not being able to fix it. You will be angry at the world for continuing to turn when your world has stopped.

The anger is real. The anger is part of the grief. The anger is not a sign that you are a bad person. The anger is a sign that you are a person who loved someone and lost them.

The anger needs to be felt. The anger needs to be expressed — in therapy, in a journal, in a letter to the spouse, in a long walk, in a primal scream in the car. The anger expressed is the anger processed. The anger expressed is the anger that does not eat you alive.

You will be relieved.

You will feel relief. The relief will be about the caregiving being over. The relief will be about the spouse no longer being in pain. The relief will be about the long goodbye being finished. The relief will come, often, in the days and weeks after the death, when the body is finally rested and the mind is finally quiet.

The relief is not a betrayal. The relief is a sign that the body has been under enormous strain. The relief is a sign that the body needs the rest. The relief is a sign that the caregiving was hard, and that the caregiver is human.

The relief will come with guilt. The relief and the guilt will come together. The relief and the guilt are both normal. The relief and the guilt will both pass, eventually.

You will be jealous.

You will be jealous. You will be jealous of couples who are still together. You will be jealous of friends whose spouses are still healthy. You will be jealous of people who get to grow old with their partners. You will be jealous of strangers in the grocery store who are complaining about their spouses, because at least they have their spouses to complain about.

The jealousy is real. The jealousy is one of the most painful emotions. The jealousy is also normal. The jealousy is a sign of how much you loved the spouse. The jealousy is a sign of how much you want the spouse back.

The jealousy will pass, eventually. The jealousy will be replaced by something softer — a kind of bittersweet feeling, a kind of "I'm glad for them" feeling, a kind of "I am still here" feeling. The jealousy will not last forever.

## **A Word About the "Shoulds"**

You will hear a lot of "shoulds." You should be over it by now. You should be dating again. You should be traveling. You should be enjoying your grandchildren. You should be grateful for the time you had. You should be moving on.

The "shoulds" are not helpful. The "shoulds" are usually said by people who have not lost a spouse. The "shoulds" are usually said by people who are uncomfortable with the grief. The "shoulds" are usually said by people who want the grief to be over because the grief makes them sad.

The "shoulds" are not your business. The "shoulds" are the business of the people who are saying them. The "shoulds" do not have to be your reality.

Your reality is whatever your reality is. Your reality is the grief, on whatever timeline your grief is on. Your reality is the rebuilding, on whatever timeline your rebuilding is on. Your reality is yours.

The next chapter is about the anger at the illness. The next chapter is about the specific kind of anger that comes from watching someone you love be taken by a disease. The next chapter is about the anger at the unfairness of it all.

# Chapter 8: The Anger at the Illness

You watched the illness take your spouse. You watched it for months. For years. You watched the illness take the body, piece by piece. You watched it take the mind, piece by piece. You watched it take the spirit, piece by piece. You watched it take the marriage, piece by piece.

You watched the illness win.

This chapter is for the anger. This chapter is for the specific kind of anger that comes from watching the illness do its work. This chapter is for the anger at the unfairness of it all.

## The Illness as Villain

The illness is the villain. The illness is the thing that took the person you love. The illness is the thing that you fought, that you held at bay, that you begged, that you bargained with, that you finally lost to.

The illness is not a person. The illness is not a thing you can yell at. The illness is not a thing you can punch. The illness is a process, a set of symptoms, a name on a chart. The illness does not hear you. The illness does not care.

The illness is also the most hated thing in your life. The illness is the thing that the anger is for. The illness is the thing that the grief is, in part, about. The illness is the thing that you would, if you could, undo.

You cannot undo the illness. The illness is in the past. The illness did its work. The illness is over. The illness is also not over — the illness is in the body of the

spouse, in the urn, in the grave. The illness is in the memory. The illness is in the anger.

## **The Anger at the Doctors**

You will be angry at the doctors. The doctors did their best. The doctors tried. The doctors were humans, with humans' limitations. The doctors were not able to save the spouse. The doctors were not able to undo the illness.

The anger at the doctors is real. The anger at the doctors is also unfair. The doctors did not cause the illness. The doctors did not make the spouse die. The doctors were, in many cases, the reason the spouse lived as long as they did.

The anger at the doctors is the anger at the limits of medicine. The anger at the doctors is the anger at the fact that there are some things medicine cannot fix. The anger at the doctors is the anger at the fact that the spouse's illness was one of those things.

The anger at the doctors can be processed in a few ways:

- Tell the doctor. Some widowed caregivers write a letter to the doctor who cared for the spouse. The letter says what the caregiver is feeling. The letter is sent, or not sent, depending on what the caregiver wants. The letter is the processing of the anger.
- Talk to a therapist. The anger at the doctors is the kind of anger that is best processed with a professional. The therapist can help the caregiver understand the anger, process the anger, and let the anger go.
- Let the anger go. The anger at the doctors is the kind of anger that does not serve the caregiver.

The anger does not change the past. The anger does not bring back the spouse. The anger is a weight that the caregiver does not need to carry. The letting go of the anger is the work of the survivor.

## **The Anger at the Spouse**

You will be angry at the spouse. The anger at the spouse is the most surprising, the most confusing, the most guilt-producing of the angers.

You will be angry at the spouse for dying. The spouse chose, in some sense, to give up. The spouse stopped fighting. The spouse let the illness win. The spouse left you alone.

The anger at the spouse is not fair. The spouse did not choose to die. The spouse did not choose the illness. The spouse did not choose to leave you. The spouse was taken, just like you were taken. The spouse did not want to die. The spouse wanted to live, with you, for as long as possible.

The anger at the spouse is also real. The anger at the spouse is the anger of the abandoned. The anger at the spouse is the anger of the person who was left. The anger at the spouse is the anger that says, You were supposed to be here. You were supposed to grow old with me. You were supposed to be the one who took care of me when I was old. You were supposed to be here.

The anger at the spouse is a sign of how much you loved the spouse. The anger at the spouse is a sign of how much the spouse's absence is felt. The anger at the spouse is a sign of the depth of the connection.

The anger at the spouse can be processed in a few ways:

- Write a letter to the spouse. The letter can say everything you are feeling. The letter can be angry. The letter can be sad. The letter can be loving. The letter can be all of these at once. The letter does not have to be sent. The letter is for you.
- Talk to the spouse, out loud. Some widowed caregivers talk to the spouse, out loud, in the empty house. The talking is not crazy. The talking is a way of processing the anger. The talking is a way of keeping the relationship alive.
- Let the anger go. The anger at the spouse is the kind of anger that does not serve the caregiver. The anger does not change the past. The anger does not bring back the spouse. The anger is a weight that the caregiver does not need to carry. The letting go of the anger is the work of the survivor. The letting go of the anger does not mean the anger was not real. The letting go of the anger means the caregiver is choosing to carry the memory of the spouse, not the anger at the spouse.

## **The Anger at God**

You will be angry at God. The anger at God is the deepest anger, the most spiritual anger, the anger that is hardest to process.

The anger at God is for the design of the world. The anger at God is for the fact that the world includes illness. The anger at God is for the fact that the world includes death. The anger at God is for the fact that good people get sick, that loving couples are separated, that the people who do the right things are not protected.

The anger at God is not a sign of weak faith. The anger at God is a sign of deep faith. The anger at God is the sign of a person who believes in a God who could have prevented this, and is angry that the God did not.

The anger at God is found in the Bible. The anger at God is found in the Psalms. The anger at God is found in the book of Job. The anger at God is found in the Quran. The anger at God is found in the Bhagavad Gita. The anger at God is a part of the human experience, in every tradition.

The anger at God can be processed in a few ways:

- Talk to God. Tell God you are angry. Tell God you do not understand. Tell God what you are feeling. The telling is a kind of prayer. The telling is a way of keeping the relationship with God alive, even in the anger.
- Talk to a clergy person. The clergy person has heard the anger before. The clergy person can hold the anger. The clergy person can help the caregiver process the anger in the context of the faith tradition.
- Let the faith evolve. The faith of the widowed caregiver often changes. The faith does not disappear. The faith evolves. The faith may become less certain. The faith may become more personal. The faith may become a faith in the love that was, rather than a faith in a God who controls the world. The evolution is normal. The evolution is the work of the survivor.
- Let the anger go. The anger at God is the kind of anger that does not serve the caregiver. The anger does not change the past. The anger does not bring back the spouse. The anger is a weight that

the caregiver does not need to carry. The letting go of the anger is the work of the survivor. The letting go of the anger does not mean the caregiver stops believing in God. The letting go of the anger means the caregiver is choosing to carry the love, not the anger.

## **The Anger at the World**

You will be angry at the world. The world will continue to turn. The world will continue to be full of people who are complaining about small things, who are taking their spouses for granted, who are wasting the time they have with the people they love.

The anger at the world is the anger of the person who has been reminded that time is limited. The anger at the world is the anger of the person who knows, now, that the time is short. The anger at the world is the anger of the person who wishes everyone could know, without having to lose a spouse to know.

The anger at the world is also a kind of wisdom. The anger at the world is the anger of the person who has learned the lesson that the world is precious, that the time is short, that the people you love are the most important thing. The anger at the world can be transformed into a commitment to live differently. The anger at the world can be transformed into a commitment to not take the people you love for granted. The anger at the world can be transformed into a commitment to use the time you have.

The transformation is the work of The Survivor. The transformation is the work of the new life. The transformation is what the loss is for, in the end.

## **A Word About the Anger Not Going Away**

The anger will not go away quickly. The anger may be with you for years. The anger will come back, sometimes, even after you think you have let it go. The anger will come back when you see a couple holding hands. The anger will come back when you hear a song that was the spouse's favorite. The anger will come back when you remember a particular moment of the illness.

The anger coming back is not failure. The anger coming back is the grief continuing. The anger coming back is the body keeping the memory of the loss. The anger coming back is the body telling you that the loss is not over.

The anger can be welcomed, when it comes. The anger can be felt. The anger can be processed. The anger can be released. The anger can be held, gently, until it passes.

The next chapter is about the first year. The next chapter is about what the first year looks like, season by season, when the spouse has died. The next chapter is about the shape of the first year, and the lessons of the first year, and the way the first year ends with a kind of survival you did not know you were capable of.

# Chapter 9: Learning to Eat Alone

The eating is the smallest thing, and the eating is the biggest thing. The eating is when the body is most reminded of the spouse. The eating is also when the body is most easily cared for. The eating is the place where the new life begins, one meal at a time.

This chapter is for the eating. This chapter is for learning to feed yourself, one meal at a time, in the absence of the person you used to feed together with.

## The First Meals

The first meals after the funeral are not real meals. The first meals are whatever the neighbors bring, whatever the family brings, whatever the friends bring. The first meals are casseroles, soups, breads, cookies. The first meals are the meals of the community, the meals of the village.

The first meals are also the meals you do not taste. The first meals are the meals you eat because someone told you to, because your body needs fuel, because the body is going to fail if you do not eat. The first meals are the meals of survival, not of pleasure.

The first meals will last for a week, for two weeks, for a month. The first meals will taper off as the community moves on. The first meals will be replaced by the meals you have to make for yourself.

The meals you have to make for yourself are the meals that matter. The meals you have to make for yourself are the meals that are the new life. The meals you have to make for yourself are the meals where the eating alone becomes real.

# The Eating Alone

The eating alone is the hardest part of the new life. The eating alone is when the chair across the table is empty. The eating alone is when the routine of cooking for two is broken. The eating alone is when the body has to feed itself, without the rhythm of the spouse's meals.

The eating alone will be uncomfortable at first. The eating alone will be uncomfortable for a long time. The eating alone will become, eventually, a thing that you do. The eating alone will become, eventually, a thing that is not the center of the grief. The eating alone will become, eventually, a part of the new normal.

Here are some things that help with the eating alone:

Make the meals small.

You do not have to make three meals a day, seven days a week. You do not have to make a full meal at every meal. You can have a piece of toast and a piece of fruit for breakfast. You can have a sandwich and some vegetables for lunch. You can have a bowl of soup and some bread for dinner. The small meals are easier to make. The small meals are easier to eat. The small meals are also better for a body that is grieving.

Make the meals simple.

You do not have to cook elaborate meals. You do not have to follow recipes. You can have the same meal three days in a row. You can have a bowl of cereal for dinner. You can have scrambled eggs for lunch. The simple meals are easier to make. The simple meals are also easier to eat alone.

Make the meals social.

You do not have to eat alone. You can eat with a friend. You can eat with a neighbor. You can eat with a family member. You can eat at a restaurant. You can eat at a community center. The social eating is the eating that is easier. The social eating is the eating that is also the rebuilding of the community.

Make the meals mindful.

You can pay attention to the meal. You can notice the colors, the smells, the textures, the tastes. You can be present with the food. The mindful eating is the eating that is also a meditation. The mindful eating is the eating that returns the body to the present moment, to the alive moment, to the moment that is not the past.

## **The Food Memories**

The food will trigger memories. The food will trigger memories of the meals you used to make together. The food will trigger memories of the meals the spouse used to make. The food will trigger memories of the meals you used to share, the meals you used to cook together, the meals you used to enjoy together.

The food memories are not bad. The food memories are the memory of the marriage. The food memories are the memory of the small daily ritual that was the cooking and the eating. The food memories are the memory of the love that was.

The food memories will come. The food memories will come every time you cook. The food memories will come every time you eat. The food memories will come when you make the spouse's favorite dish, when you eat at the restaurant the spouse used to love, when you smell a particular spice that was in the spouse's cooking.

The food memories can be welcomed. The food memories can be felt. The food memories can be honored. The food memories do not have to be the end of the meal. The food memories can be a part of the meal — a small tear, a quiet moment, a memory that you let pass through you.

The food memories will become, eventually, a part of the cooking. The food memories will be a seasoning that you add to the new meals. The food memories will be the connection to the spouse that lives in the kitchen, that lives in the cooking, that lives in the eating.

## **The Spouse's Recipes**

The spouse's recipes are a specific kind of memory. The spouse's recipes are the recipes the spouse used to make, the recipes the spouse used to love, the recipes that were the spouse's contribution to the marriage.

The spouse's recipes can be kept. The spouse's recipes can be made, on the spouse's birthday, on the anniversary, on the days when you want to feel the spouse close. The making of the spouse's recipes is a way of keeping the spouse alive in the kitchen. The making of the spouse's recipes is a way of honoring the spouse's contribution to the marriage.

The spouse's recipes can also be set aside. The spouse's recipes can be put in a box, in a drawer, in a special place, until you are ready to make them. The spouse's recipes do not have to be made now. The spouse's recipes can wait.

When you are ready to make the spouse's recipes, the making will be a kind of pilgrimage. The making will be a kind of remembrance. The making will be a way

of saying: I remember. I am still here. The love is still here.

## **A Word About the Comfort Food**

The comfort food will call to you. The comfort food will be the ice cream, the chips, the cookies, the mac and cheese, the food that is not really food but is the food that comforts.

The comfort food is allowed. The comfort food is not the enemy. The comfort food is a way of being with the grief. The comfort food is a way of giving the body something that feels like love, even when the love is gone.

The comfort food is also not the only food. The comfort food can be balanced with the real food. The comfort food can be the dessert, not the dinner. The comfort food can be the snack, not the meal. The comfort food can be the occasional treat, not the daily diet.

The balance is the work. The balance is the new life.

## **A Word About the Cooking**

The cooking will become, eventually, a pleasure. The cooking will become, eventually, a way of taking care of yourself. The cooking will become, eventually, a meditation, a creation, a gift you give to yourself.

The cooking will not feel like that for a while. The cooking will feel like a chore, a burden, a reminder that you are alone. The cooking will feel like the absence of the spouse, every time you chop an onion, every time you set the table, every time you eat the meal alone.

The cooking will, eventually, change. The cooking will become a way of feeding yourself, of nourishing

yourself, of taking care of yourself. The cooking will become a small act of self-care, repeated three times a day. The cooking will become a way of being alive, of being here, of being The Survivor.

The cooking is the work. The cooking is also the gift. The cooking is the way the body learns to care for itself, one meal at a time.

The next chapter is about the first time you smile without guilt. The next chapter is about the way the grief and the joy can coexist. The next chapter is about the smile that comes back, slowly, and the guilt that comes with it, and the work of letting the smile stay.

# **Chapter 10: The First Time You Smile Without Guilt**

The first time you smile without guilt, you will feel like a traitor. The smile will come at a moment you do not expect. The smile will be at a joke, at a scene in a movie, at a friend's story, at your grandchild's face. The smile will be small. The smile will be brief. The smile will be followed by a wave of guilt.

The wave of guilt will say: How can you smile? Your spouse just died. Your spouse is in the ground. Your spouse will never smile again. How can you smile when your spouse cannot smile?

The wave of guilt is real. The wave of guilt is part of the grief. The wave of guilt is the work of The Survivor.

This chapter is for the smile. This chapter is for the guilt. This chapter is for the way the smile and the guilt can coexist. This chapter is for the way the smile becomes, eventually, the new normal.

## **The Smile That Comes Back**

The smile will come back. The smile will come back before you think it should. The smile will come back at a moment when you are not ready. The smile will come back and surprise you.

The smile will come back because the body is designed to smile. The body is designed to find moments of joy, even in the middle of the grief. The body is designed to feel the sunlight, to hear the music, to see the beauty, to connect with the people. The body is designed to live.

The smile that comes back is not a betrayal of the spouse. The smile is the body's way of continuing to live. The smile is the body's way of honoring the spouse by being alive. The smile is the body's way of saying: I am still here. I am still capable of joy. The joy does not replace the grief. The joy is alongside the grief.

The smile that comes back is a sign of healing. The smile is not the end of the grief. The smile is the beginning of the new normal. The smile is the first sign that the new life is possible.

## **The Guilt That Comes With It**

The guilt will come with the smile. The guilt will say: You should not be smiling. You should be grieving. You should be sad. You should be in mourning. You are not taking this seriously. You are not honoring the spouse.

The guilt is real. The guilt is part of the grief. The guilt is the work of The Survivor.

The guilt comes from a few places:

- The belief that joy is a betrayal. You may believe that joy is a betrayal of the spouse. You may believe that the only honorable response to the loss is unending sadness. You may believe that the spouse would want you to be sad forever. The belief is not true. The spouse would want you to live. The spouse would want you to find joy. The spouse would not want you to be sad forever.
- The cultural expectation of mourning. The culture expects you to mourn in a specific way. The culture expects you to wear black, to be sad in public, to not enjoy things for a year. The cultural expectation is not a law. The cultural expectation

is not a rule that you have to follow. The cultural expectation is one way of mourning. There are other ways.

- The fear of forgetting. The smile may feel like the beginning of forgetting. The smile may feel like the first step toward the loss of the memory. The smile may feel like the first step toward the spouse becoming a stranger, then a memory, then a name. The fear is real. The fear is not accurate. The smile is not the first step toward forgetting. The smile is the first step toward living with the memory.
- The comparison to the spouse's absence. The smile may feel wrong because the spouse cannot smile. The spouse cannot experience joy. The spouse is gone. You are still here, smiling. The comparison is natural. The comparison is also a trap. The spouse's absence does not require your sadness. The spouse's absence does not require your unending grief. The spouse's absence is the spouse's reality. Your reality is yours.

## **The Work of Letting the Smile Stay**

The smile will come. The guilt will come with the smile. The work is to let the smile stay.

The work of letting the smile stay is the work of forgiving yourself. The work of letting the smile stay is the work of choosing to live. The work of letting the smile stay is the work of being The Survivor.

Here are some things that help with the work:

Name the smile for what it is.

When the smile comes, name it. Say to yourself: This is the smile. This is the body's way of continuing to live. This is the body's way of honoring the spouse by being alive. The smile is allowed.

The naming of the smile is the first step of letting the smile stay. The naming takes the smile out of the realm of the unconscious. The naming makes the smile a choice, not an accident.

Name the guilt for what it is.

When the guilt comes, name it. Say to yourself: This is the guilt. This is the grief trying to hold on. This is the part of me that believes joy is a betrayal. The guilt is real. The guilt is also not the truth.

The naming of the guilt is the first step of letting the guilt go. The naming takes the guilt out of the realm of the unconscious. The naming makes the guilt a thing you can choose, not a thing that controls you.

Choose the smile.

After you have named the smile and the guilt, you can choose. You can choose the smile. You can choose the joy. You can choose to let the smile stay, even when the guilt is present.

The choosing is the work. The choosing is what makes you The Survivor. The choosing is what allows the new life to begin.

The choosing is not a one-time thing. The choosing is a daily thing. The choosing is a moment-by-moment thing. The smile will come, and the guilt will come, and you will choose. The smile will come, and the guilt will come, and you will choose. The choosing is the new life.

## **The Joy That Coexists with the Grief**

The joy and the grief can coexist. The joy and the grief do not have to be enemies. The joy and the grief can be friends, of a kind — both of them present, both of them real, both of them part of the new life.

The coexistence is the wisdom of the survivor. The coexistence is the truth that the survivor learns, slowly, over the years. The coexistence is the truth that the survivor can teach to others.

The coexistence is not a balance. The coexistence is not a 50/50 split between joy and grief. The coexistence is the reality that both joy and grief are present, in different amounts at different times, and that neither one cancels out the other.

The coexistence is the truth that the survivor can live. The survivor can be joyful and grieving at the same time. The survivor can smile and cry at the same time. The survivor can find the new love and remember the old love at the same time.

The coexistence is the new normal. The coexistence is the work of The Survivor.

## **A Word About the Grandchildren**

The grandchildren are a special case. The grandchildren are the people who can bring the smile back the fastest, and the people who can trigger the guilt the most.

The grandchildren will make you smile. The grandchildren will say things, do things, see things that are so beautiful, so funny, so alive, that the smile will come before you can stop it. The grandchildren will not know about the guilt. The grandchildren will not know that you are grieving. The grandchildren will just be the grandchildren, and the smile will just be the smile.

The grandchildren will also trigger the guilt. The grandchildren will remind you of the spouse. The grandchildren will remind you of the spouse's smile, the spouse's laugh, the spouse's love for the

grandchildren. The grandchildren will remind you that the spouse is not there to see the grandchildren grow.

The grandchildren are a gift. The grandchildren are the connection to the future. The grandchildren are the proof that the love continues, that the family continues, that the line continues. The grandchildren are the reason to keep going, when the grief is the heaviest.

The grandchildren are also a kind of medicine. The grandchildren are the medicine that the spouse would have wanted you to take. The grandchildren are the medicine that the spouse would have wanted you to use.

Take the medicine. Let the grandchildren make you smile. Let the grandchildren remind you of the spouse. Let the grandchildren be the joy and the grief, both at once.

The next chapter is about the decision to keep going. The next chapter is about the moment when the surviving becomes a choice, when the surviving is no longer automatic but is something you are choosing, deliberately, every day.

# Chapter 11: The Decision to Keep Going

There will come a day when you have to decide. The day will be unremarkable. The day will be a Tuesday, or a Wednesday, or a Sunday. The day will not be marked on any calendar. The day will come when the grief is not as sharp, when the morning is not as heavy, when the body is not as tired. The day will come, and you will have to decide.

The decision is to keep going. The decision is to live. The decision is to choose the new life.

This chapter is for the decision. This chapter is for what the decision is, what the decision means, and how to make the decision when it comes.

## The Decision Is Not a Single Moment

The decision to keep going is not a single moment. The decision is not a switch that flips, not a moment of revelation, not a dramatic scene in a movie. The decision is a process. The decision is a thousand small decisions, made one after the other, over the days and months and years after the death.

The small decisions are:

- To get out of bed in the morning.
- To eat something for breakfast.
- To take a shower.
- To go for a walk.
- To call a friend.
- To answer the phone when it rings.
- To go to the doctor's appointment.

- To do the laundry.
- To pay the bills.
- To go to bed at night.
- To do it again the next day.

Each of these small decisions is the decision to keep going. Each of these small decisions is the choice to live, one more day, in the absence of the spouse. Each of these small decisions is the work of The Survivor.

The small decisions do not have to be big decisions. The small decisions do not have to be dramatic. The small decisions are the day-to-day choices that make up the new life.

## **The Decision Is a Choice, Not a Feeling**

The decision to keep going is not a feeling. The decision is a choice. The decision is something you make, not something you feel.

The feeling may not come. The feeling of "I want to keep going" may not come for a long time. The feeling of motivation, of energy, of purpose may not come. The feeling of being alive, of being here, of being The Survivor may not come.

The decision is made anyway. The decision is made on the days when the feeling does not come. The decision is made on the days when the body wants to stay in bed, when the mind wants to disappear, when the soul wants to be with the spouse. The decision is made on the days when the only thing that keeps you going is the decision to keep going.

The decision is the action. The decision is the getting out of bed, the eating of breakfast, the taking of the shower. The decision is the act, not the feeling. The

decision is the work, not the result.

The decision is what makes you The Survivor. The decision is what separates the survivor from the victim. The decision is what allows the new life to be built, one small decision at a time.

## **The Decision Is Made Every Day**

The decision to keep going is made every day. The decision is not a one-time thing. The decision is not a switch that flips, once, and stays. The decision is a daily choice, made every morning, often before the body is fully awake.

The daily decision is harder on some days than on others. The daily decision is easy on the days when the body feels rested, when the mind is clear, when the sun is shining. The daily decision is hard on the days when the body is exhausted, when the mind is dark, when the rain is falling.

The daily decision is made, on the hard days, by leaning on the things that have helped before. The daily decision is made by calling a friend. The daily decision is made by going to therapy. The daily decision is made by doing one small thing that the body can do. The daily decision is made by trusting that the hard day will pass.

The daily decision is the work of The Survivor. The daily decision is what makes the new life possible. The daily decision is the choice, every day, to be here, to be alive, to be the person who lost a spouse and is still here.

## **The Decision Is Not a Betrayal of the Spouse**

The decision to keep going is not a betrayal of the spouse. The decision is the opposite. The decision is the honoring of the spouse.

The spouse did not want you to die. The spouse did not want you to stop living. The spouse did not want you to spend the rest of your life in bed, in grief, in unending sorrow. The spouse wanted you to live. The spouse wanted you to find joy. The spouse wanted you to be happy.

The decision to keep going is the way you honor the spouse's wish. The decision to keep going is the way you honor the love that was. The decision to keep going is the way you say to the spouse: I am still here. I am still living. The love continues. The love continues in me.

The decision is the proof that the love was real. The love continues because the spouse lives on in you. The love continues because you carry the spouse in your memory, in your actions, in your heart. The love continues because you are still here.

## **The Decision Is the Beginning of the New Life**

The decision to keep going is the beginning of the new life. The decision is the moment when the surviving becomes a choice, when the surviving becomes a project, when the surviving becomes the work of building something new.

The new life will not be the same as the old life. The new life will not have the spouse. The new life will not have the routine, the plans, the shared future that the

marriage had. The new life will be different.

The new life can still be good. The new life can still be meaningful. The new life can still be filled with love, with joy, with purpose, with connection. The new life can still be a life worth living.

The new life is what you build, after the decision. The new life is the work of the survivor. The new life is the gift that the grief makes possible — the gift of knowing that life is short, that love is precious, that the time is now.

## **A Word About the Bad Days**

The bad days will come. The bad days will come even after the decision. The bad days will come on the days when the grief is sharp, when the body is tired, when the mind is dark. The bad days will come on the anniversary of the death, on the spouse's birthday, on the holidays, on the days that were the spouse's favorite.

The bad days are not a sign that the decision was wrong. The bad days are not a sign that you are not a survivor. The bad days are a sign that you are human. The bad days are a sign that the grief is real. The bad days are a sign that the love was real.

The bad days can be survived. The bad days can be made it through. The bad days can be carried, with the help of the friends, the family, the therapist, the community. The bad days will pass, eventually, and the next day will be a better day, and the day after that will be even better.

The bad days are part of the new life. The bad days are the price of the new life. The bad days are the reminder that the grief is real, the love is real, the survival is real.

The bad days do not have to win. The bad days do not have to take over. The bad days can be felt, can be honored, can be carried. The bad days can also be survived, the way the spouse would have wanted you to survive them.

## **A Word About the Good Days**

The good days will come too. The good days will come, slowly, and unexpectedly, and they will surprise you. The good days will be the days when you laugh without guilt, when you feel alive without shame, when you wake up and the first feeling is not dread but something softer, something warmer.

The good days will come, and they will be the proof that the decision was right. The good days will be the proof that the new life is possible. The good days will be the proof that the love can continue, in a different form, in the survivor's heart.

The good days are worth noticing. The good days are worth writing down. The good days are worth telling the friends about, the family about, the therapist about. The good days are the small victories that make the survival worth the work.

The good days will not always come. The good days will not always be there. The good days will come and go, the way the bad days will come and go. The good days and the bad days are both part of the new life. The good days and the bad days are both the work of The Survivor.

The next chapter is about the year mark. The next chapter is about the day that comes, one year after the death, when the first year ends and the new life begins.

# Chapter 12: The Year Mark

The year mark is the day that comes, one year after the death, when the first year ends. The year mark is a date on the calendar. The year mark is a moment of recognition. The year mark is a moment when the body knows, in a way the mind cannot deny, that the spouse has been gone for a year.

The year mark is hard. The year mark is also, in a strange way, a relief. The year mark is the end of the first year. The year mark is the beginning of the second year. The year mark is the moment when the surviving becomes real, when the new life becomes real, when the work of The Survivor is visible.

This chapter is for the year mark. This chapter is for what to expect, what to do, and what the year mark means for the new life.

## What the Year Mark Is

The year mark is the first anniversary of the death. The year mark is the day that the calendar says it has been a year since the spouse died. The year mark is a date, a moment, a marker.

The year mark is also a psychological moment. The year mark is when the body realizes, in a new way, that the spouse is not coming back. The year mark is when the mind, which has been hoping, even unconsciously, that the spouse might return, finally accepts that the spouse is gone. The year mark is the moment of the final acceptance. The year mark is the moment when the grief becomes, in some sense, permanent.

The year mark is hard because of the final acceptance. The year mark is hard because the final acceptance is a real loss — the loss of the hope, however small, that the spouse might somehow return. The year mark is hard because the year mark is the end of the first year of waiting, the first year of hoping, the first year of holding on.

The year mark is also, paradoxically, a relief. The year mark is a relief because the first year is over. The year mark is a relief because the surviving is now something that has been done, that has been accomplished, that has been survived. The year mark is a relief because the second year is beginning, and the second year is going to be different from the first.

## **What to Do on the Year Mark**

The year mark is a day to do something. The year mark is a day to mark, intentionally, the end of the first year. The year mark is a day to do something that honors the spouse, that honors the surviving, that honors the new life.

Here are some things that people do on the year mark:

- Visit the grave or the memorial. Some widowed caregivers go to the grave on the year mark. They bring flowers, or a stone, or a note. They stand at the grave and they remember. The standing is the honoring.
- Light a candle. Some widowed caregivers light a candle on the year mark. The candle burns for a few hours, or for the whole day. The candle is the symbol of the light that the spouse brought, that the spouse was, that the spouse continues to be in the survivor's heart.

- Write a letter to the spouse. Some widowed caregivers write a letter to the spouse on the year mark. The letter says what the survivor has been through, what the survivor has learned, what the survivor wants to tell the spouse. The letter is not sent. The letter is for the survivor.
- Do something the spouse loved. Some widowed caregivers do something the spouse loved on the year mark. They go to the spouse's favorite restaurant. They make the spouse's favorite meal. They visit the spouse's favorite place. The doing is the honoring.
- Do something for yourself. Some widowed caregivers do something for themselves on the year mark. They take a trip. They go to a spa. They buy themselves a gift. The doing-for-yourself is the honoring of the survivor, of the new life, of the work of the past year.
- Be with people. Some widowed caregivers are with people on the year mark. They are with friends, or family, or a support group, or a therapist. The being-with is the honoring of the community, of the friends who stayed, of the people who helped.
- Be alone. Some widowed caregivers are alone on the year mark. They take the day off. They stay in the house. They be with the memory, in private. The being-alone is also a valid choice. The being-alone is the honoring of the private grief, the private love, the private relationship with the spouse that continues.

There is no right way to do the year mark. There is only your way. The year mark is yours. The day is yours. The honoring is yours.

## **What the Year Mark Teaches**

The year mark teaches a few things. The year mark teaches the things that the first year was for.

The year mark teaches that the grief does not go away in a year. The grief is still there. The grief is still real. The grief is still part of the survivor's life. The year mark is not the end of the grief. The year mark is the end of the first year of the grief.

The year mark teaches that the survivor can survive. The year mark is the proof that the survivor has survived. The year mark is the moment when the surviving becomes real, when the surviving becomes something that has been done, when the surviving becomes a fact, not a hope.

The year mark teaches that the new life is possible. The year mark is the moment when the new life becomes real, when the new life becomes something that has been lived, when the new life becomes a fact, not a hope.

The year mark teaches that the love continues. The year mark is the moment when the love is recognized as continuing, as having survived the first year, as being a permanent part of the survivor's heart. The year mark is the moment when the love becomes, in a way, more real than the grief.

## **The Second Year**

The second year will be different from the first. The second year will have different challenges, different lessons, different kinds of grief.

The second year will be the year of the firsts — the first time you do something alone that you used to do with the spouse, the first time you go somewhere

alone that you used to go together, the first time you celebrate a holiday alone. The firsts will be hard. The firsts will also pass. The firsts will become the new normal.

The second year will be the year of the rebuilding. The second year will be the year when the surviving becomes a project, when the new life becomes a project, when the survivor starts to build the new life intentionally, deliberately, with the help of the community.

The second year will be the year of the new relationships. The second year will be the year when new friendships form, when the support group becomes a family, when the new people in the survivor's life become important. The second year will be the year when the survivor starts to have a life that is not just about the loss.

The second year will be the year of the decision. The second year will be the year when the survivor decides, more deliberately, what the new life will be. The second year will be the year when the survivor decides who to be, what to do, how to live, in the absence of the spouse.

The second year is not easier than the first. The second year is different from the first. The second year is the year of the new normal. The second year is the year of the work of The Survivor.

## **A Word About the Year Mark for the People Around You**

The year mark is also a day for the people around you. The year mark is a day when the people around you may be ready to "move on" from the loss. The year mark is a day when the people around you may be ready to stop asking how you are, stop inviting you to things, stop treating you as a person who is grieving.

The year mark is also a day when the grief is sharper than it has been in a while. The year mark is a day when the survivor may need the community more, not less. The year mark is a day when the survivor may need the friends, the family, the support group, the therapist, more than at any time in the past year.

The year mark is a day to tell the people around you what you need. The year mark is a day to say: The year mark is hard. I need you. I need the friendship. I need the calls. I need the invitations. I need the community. I am not ready to be "over" the loss. I am ready to keep living, but the living needs the community.

The people who are meant to be in the new life will hear this. The people who are not meant to be in the new life will not. The filtering is part of the work. The filtering is the new life.

The next chapter is about the years after the year mark. The next chapter is about the long journey, the years 2-5, the years when the new life becomes real, when the new identity becomes solid, when The Survivor becomes who you are.

# Chapter 13: Dating Again (or Not)

You will be asked about dating. You will be asked by your family, by your friends, by the well-meaning people in your life. The question will be gentle at first — "Have you thought about meeting someone new?" — and then, eventually, less gentle — "Don't you want to find love again? Don't you want to be happy?"

The question is a real one. The question deserves a real answer. The question does not have a one-size-fits-all answer. The question is yours to answer, in your own time, in your own way.

This chapter is for the question. This chapter is for the options. This chapter is for the deciding.

## The Question of Dating

The question of dating is the question of whether to open yourself to a new romantic relationship. The question of dating is the question of whether to let another person into the most intimate part of your life, in the most intimate way, after the loss of the most intimate person.

The question is hard because:

- The spouse is still in your heart. The spouse is still the person you compare everyone to. The spouse is still the person who knew you most completely. The spouse is still the person you would have chosen, if you had been given the choice.
- The new relationship is not the marriage. The new relationship will be different from the marriage. The new relationship will not be the

same as the marriage. The new relationship will be its own thing, with its own patterns, its own joys, its own challenges.

- The new person will not replace the spouse. The new person cannot replace the spouse. The new person will be a new person. The new person will be loved, if you choose to love them, as a new person, not as a replacement.
- The dating is scary. The dating is scary because the dating means being vulnerable again. The dating means opening yourself to the possibility of being hurt, of being disappointed, of being abandoned again. The dating means risking the grief, in a new form, in a new relationship.

The dating is also possible. The dating is possible, if you choose it, in your own time, in your own way. The dating is not a betrayal. The dating is not a sign that the spouse is forgotten. The dating is a sign that the survivor is alive, and that the survivor is willing to live.

## **The Options**

There are four options for the widowed survivor on the question of dating. None of the options is right or wrong. All of the options are valid. The options are:

Option 1: Date again, in the next year or so.

Some widowed survivors are ready to date again within a year. The widowed survivors who are ready to date quickly are often the ones who had a long caregiving, who had a chance to say goodbye, who had a chance to prepare for the loss. The widowed survivors who are ready to date quickly are also often the ones who are more social, who have a strong community, who are not as isolated by the loss.

The dating in the next year is not a betrayal. The dating in the next year is a sign that the survivor is alive, that the survivor is willing to risk, that the survivor is moving forward in the way that makes sense for them.

Option 2: Date again, after a few years.

Some widowed survivors need more time. The widowed survivors who need more time are often the ones who had a more sudden loss, who did not have a chance to say goodbye, who are still in the depths of the grief at the year mark. The widowed survivors who need more time are also often the ones who are more introspective, who need more time to process, who are not ready to be vulnerable again.

The dating after a few years is not delayed. The dating after a few years is the right timing for the survivor. The dating after a few years is a sign that the survivor knows what they need, and is willing to wait for the right time.

Option 3: Date casually, without a serious relationship.

Some widowed survivors want companionship, but not a new marriage. The widowed survivors who want casual dating are often the ones who have had a long, deep marriage and who do not want to recreate that depth with a new person. The widowed survivors who want casual dating are also often the ones who are not ready to give up their independence, who are enjoying the new freedom of being single, who do not want the responsibilities of a new serious relationship.

The casual dating is not a sign of being closed off. The casual dating is a sign of being honest about what the survivor wants. The casual dating is a way of being with people, of having companionship, of enjoying the

human connection, without the weight of a new marriage.

Option 4: Not date at all.

Some widowed survivors never date again. The widowed survivors who never date again are often the ones who had a particularly deep marriage, who cannot imagine being with someone new, who feel that the spouse was the one love of their life and that there will not be another. The widowed survivors who never date again are also often the ones who are introverts, who are not as social, who are happy with the friends and family they have.

The not-dating is not a sign of being broken. The not-dating is a sign of being honest about what the survivor wants. The not-dating is a valid choice, a respected choice, a choice that the survivor has the right to make.

## **How to Decide**

The decision of whether to date, when to date, how to date, is a personal decision. The decision is not made for the survivor by the family, the friends, the culture, the books. The decision is made by the survivor, in the survivor's own time, in the survivor's own way.

Here are some questions that may help the survivor decide:

- Am I ready to be vulnerable with a new person? Vulnerability is a precondition for dating. If the survivor is not ready to be vulnerable, the survivor is not ready to date. The vulnerability will come, in the survivor's own time.
- Am I comparing every new person to the spouse? Comparison is a sign that the survivor is not yet

ready to date. The comparison is a sign that the survivor is still in the early stages of the grief, where the spouse is the only measure of the new people. The comparison will fade, eventually, when the survivor is ready.

- Am I looking for the spouse, or for a new person? If the survivor is looking for the spouse, the survivor is not ready to date. The survivor will be disappointed by every new person, because no new person will be the spouse. The survivor needs to be looking for a new person, with the spouse in the heart but not on the search.

- Am I dating because I want to, or because someone else wants me to? If the survivor is dating because the family wants the survivor to date, the survivor is not ready to date. The dating should be for the survivor. The dating should be because the survivor wants to be with people, wants to be intimate, wants to be alive in a new way.

- Am I at peace with the marriage, even as I open to the new? If the survivor is at peace with the marriage — if the survivor has processed the grief, if the survivor has honored the spouse, if the survivor has made the decision to keep going — the survivor may be ready to date. If the survivor is not at peace, the survivor is not ready. The peace will come, in the survivor's own time.

## **A Word About the Online Dating**

The online dating is a specific thing. The online dating is the dating that happens on the apps, the websites, the platforms. The online dating is the dating that is most common in the modern world.

The online dating is also particularly hard for the widowed survivor. The online dating is hard because

the online dating requires the survivor to summarize themselves in a profile, to share the most intimate details with strangers, to be vulnerable in a way that feels dangerous. The online dating is hard because the online dating has a lot of bad actors, a lot of people who are not serious, a lot of people who are looking for something the survivor is not looking for.

The online dating can also be a gift. The online dating is a way to meet people who are also widowed, who are also looking for connection, who are also survivors. The online dating is a way to be specific about what you want, to be honest about your situation, to find the people who are right for you.

The online dating is a tool. The online dating is not the answer. The online dating is one way to meet people, not the only way. The online dating is worth trying, if you want to try it, and worth abandoning, if you do not.

## **A Word About the New Person**

If the survivor decides to date, the survivor will eventually meet a new person. The new person will be different from the spouse. The new person will be a new person. The new person will have their own history, their own patterns, their own joys, their own challenges.

The new person will also be a person. The new person will be a person who is choosing to be with the survivor, who is choosing to know the survivor, who is choosing to love the survivor, with all of the survivor's history, including the loss.

The new person will not replace the spouse. The new person cannot replace the spouse. The new person will be a new person in the survivor's life, alongside

the memory of the spouse, not in place of the spouse.

The new person can be loved. The new person can be a great love, if the survivor is open to it. The new person can be the person who helps the survivor through the next decade, the next two decades, the next three decades. The new person can be the person who helps the survivor build the new life.

The new person can also be a learning experience. The new person can be a person who is not right for the survivor. The new person can be a person who teaches the survivor what they want, what they need, what they are looking for. The new person can be a waystation on the journey, not a destination.

The new person deserves to be loved for who they are, not for who they can be for the survivor. The new person deserves the survivor's honesty, the survivor's attention, the survivor's care. The new person is a person, not a project, not a medicine, not a solution.

The next chapter is about the second chapter of your own — the new life, the new identity, the new survivor.

# **Chapter 14: The Second Chapter of Your Own**

You have been the wife, or the husband, or the partner, or the spouse. You have been the caregiver. You have been the one who did the caregiving. You have been the one who was left.

Now you are The Survivor. The Survivor is a new identity. The Survivor is not the old identity with the spouse removed. The Survivor is a new identity, with new possibilities, with new challenges, with new opportunities.

This chapter is for the new identity. This chapter is for the second chapter of your own — the chapter that comes after the marriage, after the caregiving, after the loss. The chapter that is yours.

## **The Second Chapter Is Yours**

The second chapter is yours. The second chapter is the chapter that you write, that you live, that you make real. The second chapter is not the chapter that someone else writes for you. The second chapter is not the chapter that the spouse would have wanted. The second chapter is not the chapter that the family expects, or the friends expect, or the culture expects. The second chapter is yours.

The second chapter is yours to design. The second chapter is yours to dream. The second chapter is yours to fail at, to learn from, to try again at. The second chapter is the chapter where the survivor becomes the author of their own life.

The second chapter is also a chapter of grief. The second chapter is not the end of the grief. The second

chapter is the chapter where the survivor learns to live with the grief, where the grief becomes a part of the life, where the grief is no longer the center of the life but is alongside the other things.

The second chapter is a chapter of joy. The second chapter is the chapter where the survivor finds new joys, new loves, new purposes, new reasons to get out of bed in the morning. The second chapter is the chapter where the joy is allowed, where the joy is welcome, where the joy is a sign of the survivor's aliveness.

The second chapter is a chapter of love. The second chapter is the chapter where the survivor loves, and is loved, in new ways, by new people, with the memory of the spouse in the heart. The second chapter is the chapter where the love expands, where the love grows, where the love includes the spouse, the family, the friends, the new people, the world.

The second chapter is a chapter of meaning. The second chapter is the chapter where the survivor finds the meaning of the loss, the meaning of the survival, the meaning of the life that continues. The second chapter is the chapter where the survivor decides what the loss was for, what the survival is for, what the life is for.

## **The Practices of the Second Chapter**

The second chapter has its own practices. The second chapter has the things the survivor does, every day, every week, every year, to make the new life real. The practices are not the same as the practices of the marriage. The practices are the practices of the survivor.

The practices include:

The practice of the morning.

The morning is the hardest part of the day. The morning is when the body wakes up, when the mind is most vulnerable, when the loss is most present. The morning is the time to do the things that set the tone for the day.

The practice of the morning is to do one small thing for yourself, before the day begins. The small thing can be a cup of coffee, made slowly. The small thing can be a few minutes of meditation. The small thing can be a walk around the block. The small thing can be a phone call to a friend. The small thing is the anchor for the day.

The practice of the week.

The week is the unit of the new life. The week is the rhythm of the survivor's days. The week is the time to do the things that build the new community, the new routine, the new normal.

The practice of the week is to do one thing with another person, every week. The thing can be a coffee with a friend. The thing can be a phone call to a family member. The thing can be a support group meeting. The thing can be a class, a volunteer activity, a religious service. The thing is the connection. The connection is the new life.

The practice of the month.

The month is the time to do the things that require more planning. The month is the time to do the things that build the new identity, the new routine, the new dream.

The practice of the month is to do one thing that is for your own growth, every month. The thing can be a book you have been meaning to read. The thing can be

a class you have been meaning to take. The thing can be a trip you have been meaning to take. The thing can be a project you have been meaning to start. The thing is the becoming. The becoming is the new identity.

The practice of the year.

The year is the time to do the things that mark the new life. The year is the time to do the things that say: I am still here. I am still living. The life continues.

The practice of the year is to do one thing that honors the spouse, every year. The thing can be a visit to the grave. The thing can be a donation in the spouse's name. The thing can be a gathering of the family on the anniversary. The thing can be a letter to the spouse, written and read. The thing is the honoring. The honoring is the love that continues.

## **The Work of the Second Chapter**

The second chapter has its work. The second chapter is not retirement. The second chapter is not the end of the work. The second chapter is the beginning of a new work, the work of the survivor, the work of the new life.

The work of the second chapter is:

- To grieve, when the grief comes.
- To laugh, when the laughter comes.
- To love, when the love comes.
- To work, when the work needs to be done.
- To rest, when the rest is needed.
- To give, when the giving is wanted.
- To receive, when the receiving is offered.
- To fail, when the failure is part of the learning.

- To try again, when the trying is what the work requires.

The work of the second chapter is the work of being alive. The work of the second chapter is the work of being The Survivor. The work of the second chapter is the work that the spouse would have wanted for you.

## **The Possibilities of the Second Chapter**

The second chapter has its possibilities. The second chapter is the time of the new dreams, the new plans, the new visions. The second chapter is the time of the possibilities that were not possible in the marriage, in the caregiving, in the loss.

The possibilities include:

- The possibility of travel. The travel that you put off during the caregiving. The travel that you put off because of the cost, the time, the responsibility. The travel that is now possible, in the new freedom of the single life.
- The possibility of learning. The learning that you put off during the caregiving. The learning of a new language, a new skill, a new art. The learning that is now possible, in the new freedom of the single life.
- The possibility of the new relationship. The relationship that may come, in the new life. The relationship that is not the marriage but is its own thing. The relationship that is one of the possibilities of the new life.
- The possibility of the legacy. The legacy that you can build, in the new life. The legacy of the values, the love, the work that you did. The legacy that you can pass on, to the children, to the

grandchildren, to the world.

- The possibility of the meaning. The meaning that you can find, in the loss. The meaning that the loss is not just a loss, but is also a transformation. The meaning that the survivor is not just a victim, but is also a person who has been through something and has come out the other side.

## **A Word About the Spouse in the Second Chapter**

The spouse is in the second chapter. The spouse is in the second chapter not as a presence, but as a memory. The spouse is in the second chapter not as a partner, but as a teacher. The spouse is in the second chapter not as a person you talk to every day, but as a person you think of, often, with love.

The spouse's love continues. The spouse's values continue. The spouse's lessons continue. The spouse is in the new life, in the choices you make, in the way you treat the people you love, in the way you face the challenges of the new life.

The spouse is in the second chapter. The spouse is the foundation of the second chapter. The second chapter is built on the marriage, on the caregiving, on the loss, on the love. The second chapter is not a rejection of the marriage. The second chapter is the continuation of the marriage, in a different form, in a different life, with the spouse in the heart.

The next chapter is about the legacy of the caregiving years. The next chapter is about what the caregiving was for, what the loss was for, what the survival is for. The next chapter is about the meaning of the long goodbye.

But for now, just be in the second chapter. The second chapter is yours. The second chapter is the work. The second chapter is the gift.

# Chapter 15: The Legacy of the Caregiving Years

The caregiving years took a lot. The caregiving years took your time, your energy, your health, your sleep, your career, your relationships, your savings, your youth, your sense of self. The caregiving years took a lot from you.

The caregiving years also gave something. The caregiving years gave you a depth you did not have before. The caregiving years gave you a wisdom you did not have before. The caregiving years gave you a strength you did not know you had. The caregiving years gave you a love that you now know is bigger than you thought possible.

This chapter is for the legacy. This chapter is for what the caregiving was for, what the loss was for, what the survival is for. This chapter is for the meaning of the long goodbye.

## The Caregiving as Gift

The caregiving was a gift. The gift is not obvious. The gift is wrapped in pain, in exhaustion, in grief, in loss. The gift is not the kind of gift you would have asked for. The gift is the kind of gift that only becomes visible in the looking back.

The gift of the caregiving is the gift of knowing that you can love. The caregiving was the longest, hardest test of your love. The caregiving was the test that you did not choose but that you passed. The caregiving was the proof that your love is not just a feeling, but is a practice, a daily choice, a thousand small acts of care.

The gift of the caregiving is the gift of knowing what matters. The caregiving stripped away the things that did not matter. The caregiving showed you, in the most painful way, that the things that matter are the simplest things — the touch, the laugh, the morning coffee, the evening walk, the hand on the back, the "I love you" said out loud. The things that matter are the things you can do for the person you love.

The gift of the caregiving is the gift of knowing who you are. The caregiving showed you, in the hardest way, who you are. The caregiving showed you that you are the kind of person who shows up. The caregiving showed you that you are the kind of person who does the work. The caregiving showed you that you are the kind of person who loves, even when the loving is hard.

The gift of the caregiving is the gift that you will give, in turn, to others. The caregiving taught you how to be with people who are suffering. The caregiving taught you how to sit with pain, how to hold a hand, how to be present in the hardest moments. The caregiving taught you how to be the friend, the family member, the caregiver that the people around you need.

## **The Loss as Transformation**

The loss was a transformation. The loss did not just take something from you. The loss changed you. The loss made you into a different person. The loss made you into The Survivor.

The loss is not just an ending. The loss is also a beginning. The loss is the end of the marriage, and the beginning of the new life. The loss is the end of the caregiving, and the beginning of the surviving. The loss is the end of the spouse-as-partner, and the

beginning of the spouse-as-memory.

The loss is not just a subtraction. The loss is also an addition. The loss added to you the experience of grief, the experience of surviving, the experience of being a person who has been through the worst and is still here. The loss added to you the community of survivors, the friends who stayed, the wisdom that only the bereaved know.

The loss is not just a wound. The loss is also a teacher. The loss taught you, in the hardest way, what the love was. The loss taught you, in the hardest way, what the marriage was. The loss taught you, in the hardest way, what the life is. The loss taught you, in the hardest way, what you are.

## **The Survival as Practice**

The survival is a practice. The survival is not a one-time achievement. The survival is a daily practice, a daily choice, a daily decision to keep going.

The survival is the practice of getting out of bed, when the bed is the easier place. The survival is the practice of eating the breakfast, when the breakfast is not appealing. The survival is the practice of making the phone call, when the phone call is hard. The survival is the practice of going to the appointment, when the appointment is exhausting. The survival is the practice of being with the friend, when the being-with is also being-with-the-grief.

The survival is the practice of being alive. The survival is the practice of being present. The survival is the practice of being a person, in the world, with the loss, with the love, with the memory, with the future.

The survival is the practice that the spouse would have wanted for you. The survival is the practice that

honors the love. The survival is the practice that says: I am still here. The love continues. The life continues.

## **The Legacy for the Children and Grandchildren**

The caregiving years and the loss have a legacy for the children and grandchildren. The legacy is not the death, the illness, the loss. The legacy is the love, the caregiving, the example, the memory.

The legacy for the children is the example of the love. The legacy for the children is the example of the marriage, the example of the caregiving, the example of the way the survivor and the spouse treated each other, in the good times and in the bad. The children will remember, in the years to come, the way the survivor and the spouse loved each other. The children will carry that memory with them, into their own marriages, their own families, their own lives.

The legacy for the children is the example of the surviving. The legacy for the children is the example of the way the survivor rebuilt the life after the loss. The children will remember, in the years to come, the way the survivor kept going, the way the survivor found the joy, the way the survivor built the new life. The children will carry that example with them, into their own challenges, their own losses, their own survivals.

The legacy for the grandchildren is the story. The legacy for the grandchildren is the story of the marriage, the caregiving, the loss, the survival. The grandchildren will hear the story, when they are old enough. The grandchildren will carry the story with them, into their own lives. The story will be the connection to the spouse they never knew, the

great-grandparent they will know only through the story.

The story is worth telling. The story is worth telling well. The story is worth telling to the children, to the grandchildren, to the friends, to the community. The story is the legacy. The story is the love that continues.

## **The Legacy for the Community**

The caregiving years and the loss have a legacy for the community. The legacy is the example, the wisdom, the contribution.

The legacy for the community is the example of the survivor. The legacy for the community is the example of the person who lost a spouse and is still here, the example of the person who is rebuilding the life, the example of the person who is finding the joy. The community will see the survivor, and the community will learn from the survivor, that the loss is not the end. The community will learn from the survivor that the loss is also a beginning.

The legacy for the community is the wisdom of the survivor. The legacy for the community is the wisdom of the person who has been through the worst and has come out the other side. The survivor can offer that wisdom to the community, through the support group, through the volunteer work, through the conversation with the friend who is just starting the journey. The wisdom is a gift. The wisdom is the contribution.

The legacy for the community is the contribution of the survivor. The survivor can contribute to the community in many ways — through volunteering, through advocacy, through writing, through the simple act of being present, of being with the people

who are suffering, of being the friend who knows what to do because the friend has been through the worst.

## **A Word About the Meaning**

The meaning of the caregiving, the loss, the survival, is not given. The meaning is made. The meaning is what the survivor decides it is.

The meaning can be the meaning of the gift — the meaning of the love, the meaning of the practice, the meaning of the showing up.

The meaning can be the meaning of the transformation — the meaning of the new identity, the new community, the new wisdom.

The meaning can be the meaning of the legacy — the meaning of the example, the story, the contribution.

The meaning can also be the meaning of the simple survival — the meaning of being here, of being alive, of being The Survivor.

The meaning is yours. The meaning is what you make it. The meaning is the work of the new life.

The next chapter is the epilogue — the short closing that ties the book together. The epilogue is the breath after the work. The epilogue is the look back at the climb, and the look forward at the view.

The view is real. The view is worth the climb.

# Epilogue: What I Wish Someone Had Told Me

I lost my wife of many years to cancer. I was her primary caregiver. I held the medical schedule, the medication schedule, the family schedule, the work schedule, the insurance schedule. I held her hand. I held her fear. I held mine.

She died on a Tuesday morning at 6:47 a.m. I was holding her hand.

I am writing this book from the other side of that. I am writing this book as a widower, as a survivor, as a man who has lived the first morning, the first year, the first decade, without her.

I am writing this book because no one gave me a book like this after she died. I am writing this book because I now know what I needed to know then. I am writing this book because the widowed caregivers I work with need a companion for the journey.

Here is what I wish someone had told me.

## **1. The grief is not a problem to be solved.**

The grief is not a problem. The grief is a process. The grief is the body's way of carrying the love, after the person is gone. The grief is not something to be fixed, or cured, or gotten over. The grief is something to be felt, and honored, and carried.

I wish someone had told me that the grief would still be with me, ten years later. I wish someone had told me that the grief is not a sign of failure, or weakness, or being stuck. The grief is a sign of love. The grief

continues because the love continues.

## **2. The first year is the hardest.**

The first year is the year of the most intense grief. The first year is the year of the most disorienting loss. The first year is the year when the surviving is the hardest.

I wish someone had told me that the first year would have a shape. The first year has a shape — the first three months, the next three months, the next six months. The first year has a rhythm, a pattern, a way it goes. I wish someone had given me a map for the first year, the way this book gives you a map.

## **3. The community matters more than you think.**

The community is what carries you. The community is the friends who bring the food, the family who stays with you, the support group who understands, the therapist who helps you process. The community is the lifeline.

I wish someone had told me, after my wife died, that the community would show up in unexpected ways. The community was not the people I expected. The community was the people who showed up. The community was the people who stayed.

## **4. The new life is possible.**

The new life is possible. I am proof. Ten years after my wife died, I have a new life. The new life is not the same as the old life. The new life is different — different in the routines, different in the relationships, different in the dreams. The new life is also good.

I wish someone had told me, after my wife died, that the new life would come. I wish someone had told me that the new life would be different, but not worse. I wish someone had told me that the new life would include joy, and laughter, and even love, in a different form, in a different time.

## **5. The spouse is still with you.**

The spouse is still with you. The spouse is in the memory. The spouse is in the values. The spouse is in the lessons. The spouse is in the children. The spouse is in the choices you make, every day, the way you treat the people you love, the way you face the challenges of the new life.

I wish someone had told me, after my wife died, that she was not gone. She was not gone. She was in my heart, in my mind, in the choices I make, in the way I hold the grief. She was with me when I went for a walk. She was with me when I made the coffee. She was with me when I cried. She was with me when I laughed. She was with me. She is still with me.

## **6. The decision to keep going is yours.**

The decision to keep going is yours. The decision is not made by the family, the friends, the culture, the books. The decision is made by you, in your own time, in your own way.

I made the decision, after my wife died, to keep going. I made the decision to live. I made the decision to find the joy. I made the decision to be The Survivor.

The decision was the hardest thing I have ever done. The decision was also the most important thing I have ever done. The decision is what made the new life

possible.

## **7. The widowed caregivers are not alone.**

The widowed caregivers are not alone. The widowed caregivers are part of a community. The widowed caregivers are part of a tradition. The widowed caregivers are part of a movement of people who have been through the worst and have come out the other side.

I wish someone had told me, after my wife died, that the widowed caregivers are a community. The widowed caregivers are the people who understand, who do not need to be told, who can hold the grief, who can be with the pain, who can offer the wisdom. The widowed caregivers are you. The widowed caregivers are me. The widowed caregivers are us.

## **A Final Word**

You are reading this book. The fact that you are reading this book is a sign that you are not giving up. The fact that you are reading this book is a sign that you are willing to find out what comes next. The fact that you are reading this book is a sign that you are The Survivor.

I cannot tell you what comes next. I can tell you that something comes next. I can tell you that the something is yours to build. I can tell you that the building is worth the work.

This book is for the building. This book is the companion. This book is the voice of one widower to another, saying: You are not alone. You are not forgotten. You are The Survivor. The life continues. The love continues. The work continues.

Welcome to the new life. Welcome to the second chapter. Welcome to the survivor's work.

— S. Shharma, India, August 2026

Widower. Writer. Father. Survivor.

# About the Author

S. Shharma is the author of The Care Collection — books for couples in the second half of life, written by a man who lived the silence and survived it.

He lost his wife of many years to cancer. He was her primary caregiver through every stage of her illness. He held her hand in the hospital. He sat in the waiting room at 3 a.m. He learned the silence of a marriage the way you learn a language you never wanted to speak.

He is also a businessman, an M.Sc., an MBA, and an APSCM from the Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Calcutta, with thirty years in corporate management. But these are not credentials you need to trust him. The credentials that matter are the ones in the books.

The Care Collection is not about how to fix a marriage. The Care Collection is about how to live one — even when the marriage is quiet, even when one of you is sick, even when one of you is gone.

He lives in India. He writes from the perspective of someone who has been on every side of a marriage — the partner, the caregiver, and the one left behind.

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THE CARE COLLECTION / BOOK 5

# The Survivor

Rebuilding Your Life After Losing Your Spouse at 55+  
When One Spouse Is Left Behind

**You lost the love of your life.  
The house is too quiet.  
You are still here.**

A 4-phase framework for the widowed caregiver - the one who held on for years, and is now learning to let go. With case studies, grief tools, and crisis resources for the US, UK, and India.

## Inside this book:

- The 4-Phase Framework: Survival, Grief, Rebuilding, New Life
- 5 Case Studies of Real Widowers
- Grief Tools and Self-Care Practices
- Crisis Resources: US, UK, India
- Bonus: 12 Research Citations

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